

Arba Minch University

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Notes for Communicative English Language Skills-I (FLEn 1011)

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Session One: Grammar and Its Usage

Communicative grammar is the grammar of utterances — that is, words that we actually use in communicative situations, rather than the sentence grammar that discusses the rules of correct use. Communicative grammar teaches students to use the language appropriately in meaningful situations to perform functions such as accepting or rejecting an invitation, or providing and getting information, and is built around topics rather than grammar rules.

Communicative strategies are the skills that speakers use to communicate their feelings effectively so that the attention of the listener is drawn to the meaning the speaker wishes to convey through the utterances, rather than the grammatical form. Communicative strategies also include the ability of people to *respond* appropriately in conversation, whether the situation is formal (classrooms, meetings, ceremonies) or informal (parties, family events, festivals).

1. Tenses

1.1 Present Tenses

A. Simple Present Tense (Its Forms and Functions)

The present simple has the form of the infinitive. But in the third (3rd) person singular only, we add “-s, es or ies” depending on the nature of the verb. In such form, the negative statements and questions are formed with **do**-when the subject is in plural form whereas **does**-when the subject is in singular form.

- a) I write. She writes.
- b) I don't write. She doesn't write.
- c) Do I write? Does she write?

Uses of Simple Present Tense

- ✓ We use the present simple to say that something happens repeatedly, regularly, normally, often, always or never. It often occurs with phrases of time such as always, never, often, sometimes, and usually, as well as every summer, on Fridays, after midnight, etc.
 - e.g. He often goes to bed after midnight.
- ✓ The present simple is used to talk about something permanent which is not limited to a particular time.
 - e.g. Most young people like trendy clothes.
- ✓ The present simple is used to talk about texts, e.g. novels, short stories, newspaper articles, films or plays.
 - e.g. The novel describes life in desert areas.
- ✓ We use the present simple to describe a series of action, e.g. when giving information or instructions.

- e.g. “How do I get to the bus station?”
“First you go along Chamo Campus Street, then you turn left/right ...”
- ✓ We use the present simple to say that a future event is a fixed part of a timetable, a program of events, a schedule or such like (the “timetable future”). Verbs such as arrive, open, close, start or stops are often used this way.

B. Present Continuous Tense (Its Forms and Functions)

We form the present progressive with ‘*subject + am/is/are + -‘ing verb’ in declarative sentences’ but ‘am/is/are’ + subject in question form.*

- a) I am writing.
- b) You are not writing.
- c) Is she writing?

Uses of Present Continuous Tense

- ✓ The present progressive is used when we want to say that somebody is doing something or that something is happening at the moment. The action or event is in progress and not yet complete. Common phrases of time are at the moment, now, just and still.
 - e.g. Hiwot is washing her hair (at the moment).
- ✓ The present progressive is used for actions which are not yet complete but can be interrupted for a time. Strictly speaking, such interrupted actions are not in progress at the moment of speaking.
 - e.g. I’m very busy. I’m redecorating my living-room.
- ✓ We use the present progressive to express the idea that a repeated action is temporary, i.e. It is happening for a limited period of time.
 - e.g. Abera is working at a restaurant during his holidays.
- ✓ We can use the adverb always with the present progressive to say that something happens again and again, although not at regular intervals. Here always means very often or too often. The structure expresses the speaker’s annoyance or surprise.
 - e.g. You’re always forgetting your books!
- ✓ We use the present progressive to say that something is definitely planned or arranged for the future. It must be clear from the context or from the use of a phrase of future time (this afternoon, on Sunday, next week, etc.) that we are talking about the future.
 - e.g. We’re having a get together ceremony on the coming Sunday.

Activity-1: Put the following verbs into the correct tense—either the present simple or the present progressive. Use all the elements in the brackets. Note the importance of certain key words. Use a highlighter to indicate the key words on your note book.

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1. They (want) to stay here for another week. | 12. (you, think) he would come if we asked him? |
| 2. This tea (taste) like dishwater. | 13. How much (you, owe) me? |
| 3. Look! He (come) now. | 14. (I, not, go) with you tomorrow? Isn't there enough room in the car? |
| 4. What (you, do)? I (try) to make some jam but everybody (keep) asking me what I (do), so I (not, make) much progress. | 15. It (look) as if it is going to rain. |
| 5. My car (always, break) down. | 16. (you, not, want) to come walking with me? |
| 6. She (not, earn) very much but she (buy) her first car next week. | 17. I hope you (understand) what I (talk) about today. |
| 7. We (think) of going there next week. | 18. (you, go) to market on Wednesday? |
| 8. I (see) the doctor on Thursday. | 19. (you, remember) when you were very small? |
| 9. He (always, forget) to bring his books. | 20. I (wish) he would stop phoning me at eleven o'clock at night. He (always, do) it! |
| 10. This book (belong) to Brian. | |
| 11. What (you, do)? I (think) about what I've got to do tomorrow. | |

C. Present Perfect Tense (Its Forms and Functions)

We form the present perfect with **subject + have/has + the past participle** in declarative sentence whereas **have/has + subject + the past participle (V3)** in question form. For example;

- I have lost my keys.
- She has not lost her keys.
- Have you lost your keys?

Uses of Present Perfect Tense

- ✓ We use the present perfect to say that someone has done something or that something has happened. The exact time is not important (or is unknown) and is not mentioned. The action or event often has direct consequences for the present or the future.
 - e.g I've seen that movie twenty times.
- ✓ Some common phrases of time are **just, already, always, never, rarely, seldom, before, ever, lately, recently, often, still not, so far, up to now, not yet, yet?**
 - e.g Have you ever been to Ireland? I've been to Ireland four times so far.
- ✓ The present perfect is used to express the idea that a state began in the past and is still continuing. Some common phrases are **always, all week, since and for**.
 - e.g I've had this car for two years.
- ✓ The present perfect is used to express a finished action in an unfinished period of time.
 - e.g I have seen him this morning. (I have seen him = finished; this morning = unfinished)

Note!

- ✓ You cannot use the present perfect with expressions such as yesterday, one year ago, last week, etc. You have to use the past simple because these expressions refer to a specific point of time in the past. Compare the following two sentences as example;

- I met a lot of people two days ago.
- I've met a lot of people in the last few days.

Activity-2: For each situation, write a sentence using the words in brackets.

1. Ruth is from Australia. She is travelling round Europe at the moment. She began her trip three months ago. (travel / for three months).
2. Gemachu is a tennis player. He began playing tennis when he was ten years old. This year he is national champion again – for the fourth time. (win / the national championships / four times)
3. When they left college, Lisan and Sara started making films together. They still make films. (make / five films since they left college).

D. Present Perfect Continuous Tense (Its Forms and Functions)

We form the present perfect progressive with '*subject + have/has + been + -ing verb*'.

- a) I have been writing.
- b) I have not been writing.
- c) Have I been writing?

Uses of Present Perfect Continuous Tense

- ✓ The present perfect progressive is generally used with verbs which imply continuous actions. Often these verbs describe actions which started at some time in the past and have continued (almost) up to the present and/or will probably continue into the future. Some common phrases of time are *all day, the whole morning, since and for*. For example;
- a) Oh, have you woken up? You have been sleeping for more than ten hours.
 - b) Almaz has been working since early this morning, and she hopes to finish soon.
 - c) We've been living in Arba Minch for six years.
 - d) Patrick has been running. (Now he is out of breath.)
- ✓ We use the present progressive after recently, lately or how long...? For example;
- a) How long have you been playing the guitar?
 - b) Recently, I have been feeling really tired.
 - c) She has been watching too much television lately.

Note!

- ✓ The negative form of the present perfect progressive is quite rare. It is usually replaced by the negative form of the present perfect simple. For example;
- She hasn't studied French since 2007.

- ✓ If the number of times that an action has taken place (the result of the activity) is given or implied, then the simple form is used. For example'
 - She has written ten letters this morning.
- ✓ Do not use the progressive form for an abrupt or sudden action. For example;
 - He has driven my car into a wall.

Activity-3:

I. Put the verb into the more suitable form, the present perfect simple or present perfect progressive.

1. Lemlem is away on holiday. – Is she? Where (she, go / be) _____?
2. Sorry, I'm late. – That's all right. (I, not wait) _____ long.
3. Is it still raining? – No, (it, stop) _____.
4. (I, lose) _____ my address book. (you, see) _____ it?
5. (I, read) _____ the book you lent me, but (I, not finish) _____ it yet. It's very interesting.
6. (I, read) _____ the book you lent me, so you can have it back now.

II. Put the following verbs into the correct tense—either the present perfect or the present perfect progressive, but use the progressive form wherever possible. Use any other information given, and select for or since where necessary. Note the importance of certain keywords.

1. You (come) too late, Doctor. The poor man (just, die).
2. He (always, detest) travelling by bus, and he (never, like) travelling by car either.
3. Jemal (see) the Bale National Park five times.
4. A bee (sting) me!
5. The workers (now, finish) building that supermarket. Apparently it (take) them a lot longer to build it than they thought it would.
6. That nice Dr. Lindsay? No, officer, I (not, see) him or his energetic wife (for/since) ages.
7. She (only, know) Charles (for/since) she was sixteen, but they (live) in the same town (for/since) they were born.
8. Mr. Abebe (bring) me my newspapers (for/since) over fifteen years.
9. They (write) to me fourteen times (since/for) the beginning of the month.
10. She (work) on her book (for/since) last year, and she hopes to complete it by Christmas.

2.2 Past Tenses

A. Simple Past Tense (Its Forms and Functions)

We form the past simple of regular verbs by adding ‘-ed,-d or -ied’ to the infinitive. But irregular verbs have their own forms. We form negative statements and questions with did. For example;

- a) I worked a lot.
- b) She didn’t read my letter.
- c) Did you call her?

Uses of Simple Past Tense

- ✓ We use the past simple to say that something happened at a particular point of time in the past (answering the question when?) or in a particular period of time in the past (which is now over). The point or period of time can be mentioned, or it may be clear from the context. Some common phrases of time are yesterday, in 1998, last year, an hour ago, etc. We also use the past simple (not the present perfect) after when ...? For example;
 - a) Fatiya passed her driving test in 1998.
 - b) When did you last see your coach?
- ✓ The past simple is also used in reports about past events and in stories.
 - E. g. It was late. Genet turned off the TV and went upstairs. ...
- ✓ We use the past simple when giving more information about a past event we have introduced in the present perfect. The past simple is used to give further details, Where and how something happened.
 - e.g There has been an accident in Arba Minch Street. A van crashed into a bus. The bus stopped abruptly and three people were injured.
- ✓ When two or more (short) actions in the past come directly one after the other, we use the past simple for all the actions.
 - e.g The cat ran out when John opened the door.

B. Past Continuous Tense (Its Forms and Functions)

The past progressive uses with ‘*subject + was/were + -ing verb*’: For example;

- a) I was working.
- b) She was not reading.
- c) Were you listening to me?

Uses of Past Continuous Tense

- ✓ We use the past progressive to say that something was in progress (going on) around a particular past time.
 - e.g “What were you doing at eight o’clock yesterday?” – “I was watching TV.”

- ✓ We often use the past progressive together with the past simple. The past progressive refers to a longer ‘background’ action or situation; the past simple refers to a shorter action or event that happened in the middle of the longer action, or that interrupted it. For example;
 - a) As I was walking down the road, I saw my uncle.
 - b) The phone rang while I was having dinner.
- ✓ Because we often use the past progressive to talk about something that is a ‘background’, not the main ‘news’, we can make something seem less important. Compare:
 - a) I had lunch with the President yesterday. (Important piece of news)
 - b) I was having lunch with the President yesterday, and she said... (as if there was nothing special for the speaker about lunching with the President.)
- ✓ The past progressive is not the normal tense for talking about repeated or habitual past actions. (Use the past simple here.)
 - a. I rang the bell six times.
 - b. When I was a child, we made our own amusements.

Activity-4: Put the following verbs into the correct tense—either the past simple or the past progressive.

1. When he (be) younger, he (grow) vegetables for the whole family.
2. Sarah (meet) Mrs Jones while she (do) her shopping.
3. (he, break) his leg while he (play) football?
4. She (drop) the glass because she (carry) too much.
5. Kemal (meet) his brother while he (work) as a procter in AMU.
6. Mr and Mrs Smith (lose) their passports while they (travel) through California.
7. All the time I (write) a letter, she (try) to practice the piano.
8. While I (be) in town yesterday, I (call) you four times.
9. This morning, as I (come) out of the house, the sun (rise).
10. He (steal) lots of cars before the police (catch) him.
11. What (you, do) all the time I (work) in the garden?

C. Past Perfect Tense (Its Forms and Functions)

- ✓ We form the past perfect with ‘*subject + had + the past participle*’. For example;
 - a) I had written a letter.
 - b) She had not read my letter.
 - c) Had you worked?

Uses of Past Perfect Tense

- ✓ With the help of the past perfect we can express the idea that one past action followed another. The action that happened first is in the past perfect.
 - e.g Fiona had already left the coffee bar by the time I arrived.

- ✓ The past perfect is also used to refer to a state. The state began before a point of time in the past and continued to that time.

- e.g When I visited Patrick in hospital, he had been there for ten days.

- ✓ We use the past perfect for an action only when we need to emphasize that it happened before another action. Compare:

- a) When Girma's friends arrived, he had cooked the lunch.

- b) When Girma's friends arrived, he cooked the lunch.

D. Past Perfect Continuous Tense (Its Forms and Functions)

We form the past perfect progressive with ' *subject + had been + -ing verb*'. For example;

- a) I had been writing.

- b) I had not been working.

- c) Had she been writing?

Uses of Past Perfect Continuous Tense

- ✓ We use the past perfect progressive to express the idea that an action or event had begun before a point of time in the past and continued up to (or almost up to) that time.

- e.g Abdisa had been travelling for three months when he ran out of money.

2.3 Future Tenses

I. Simple Future Tense (Ways of expressing future events)

A) 'Will-future'

- ✓ We use the will-future when we want to make a prediction or an assumption about the future. Common phrases are *I think, expect, wonder, hope ..., probably, perhaps, maybe, I'm sure ...*

- e.g I think Fatuma will study her MA program here.

- ✓ We use the will-future when we want to make a spontaneous decision, an offer or a promise.

- e.g "It's raining!" – "I'll lend you my umbrella."

- ✓ We use the will-future when we want to describe facts in the future.

- e.g Guta will be twenty-four next Thursday.

- ✓ We use the will-future in *conditional sentences type I*.

- e.g If you book your flight early, you'll get it cheaper.

- ✓ We use the will-future with the following time conjunctions: *after, when, until, before, as soon as*.

- e.g We'll play cards as soon as she arrives.

B. 'Be Going to-future'

- ✓ We use the '*be going to-future*' when we talk about intentions or plans for the future.

- e.g Tonight I am going to watch the football match on TV.

- ✓ We use the '*be going to-future*' when something will very probably happen because there are already signs of it happening.

- e.g "Look at those black clouds! It's going to rain."

C. Using Present Progressive

- ✓ We use the present progressive when something is definitely planned or arranged for the future.
 - e.g We're flying to Bahir Dar on the coming Saturday.

D. Using Present Simple

- ✓ We use the present simple when a future event is a fixed part of a timetable, program, schedule or suchlike.
 - e.g The first bus to Hawassa leaves at 6.20 tomorrow morning.

II) Future Progressive

- ✓ We use the future progressive when an action or event will be in progress at a point of time in the future.
 - e.g This time on Saturday I will be flying to Bahir Dar.
- ✓ We use the future progressive when something will happen because it normally happens.
 - e.g In a few minutes, we'll be arriving at Nechsar National Park.

III) Future Perfect

- ✓ We use the future perfect when an action or event will be complete at a point of time in the future.
 - e.g I suppose the department head will have left when we arrive.

Was / Were Going To:

Note: The existence of was / were going to, which can indicate a past intention or a plan that has since been changed ('future in the past').

- e.g I was going to work in the garden, but then it started to rain.

Activity-5: Put the following verbs into the correct future or present tense to express a future meaning. Beware of a few sentences which need the imperative or the 'was/were going to' form.

1. They (dream) of Spain as soon as they (get) home from their holidays.
2. I (fly) to Scotland but when I found out how expensive it was, I changed my mind.
3. (she, break) down when she (hear) of her son's accident?
4. When you (break) your leg, (not, come) crying to me saying I never warned you.
5. She (burst) the balloon if she (blow) it up any more.
6. "(you, work) in the garden this afternoon?" - "What! You're joking! It (be) far too hot to do any work outside, I think I (stay) in the living room and have rest."

2. Conditional Sentences (Its Forms and Functions)

Conditional sentences are in the **conditional mood** (a sub-category of the **subjunctive mood**), which is used for hypothetical scenarios that are dependent on a certain condition or conditions. They are usually constructed using *if* to identify the conditions that must be met. There are four “degrees” of conditionals, all of which vary in structure and meaning.

A) Zero Conditional

A **zero conditional** sentence uses the **present simple tense** to talk about what is always or generally true. It is classified as a conditional because it creates a hypothetical situation to describe what *would be* true each time something happens. The general structure for the zero conditional is: “If + subject + present tense of predicate verb, subject + present tense of main verb.” For example:

- a. “**If** you **throw** a ball in the air, it **comes** back down.” (Always true: A ball comes back down every time you throw it in the air.)
- b. “**If** we **get up** early, we always **go** jogging.” (Generally true: We jog every time we get up early.)

B) First Conditional

The **first conditional** is very similar in structure to the zero conditional. We still use *if* plus the present simple to create the condition, except that we now use the **future simple tense** (*will* + bare infinitive) to describe a probable result of the condition. Thus, the structure is: “*If* + present simple tense, *will* + infinitive.” For example:

- a. “**If** I **see** him, I **will** tell him.”
- b. “**If** I **win** the lottery, I **will** buy a new house.”

We can also create negative first conditionals by using the negative of the present simple in the *if* clause, and the negative of *will* in the future simple clause. For example:

- a. “**If** I **do not** go, I **will not** see him.”
- b. “**If** I **don’t** see him, I **won’t** have to say goodbye.”
- c. “**If** he **doesn’t** arrive soon, we **won’t** have time to catch the 9:30 train.”

We can also reorder the sentence to have the future tense clause at the beginning of the sentence, and the *if* conditional clause at the end. Additionally, we can use **modal auxiliary verbs** other than *will* (such as *must*, *can*, *could*, *may*, *might*, or *should*) to create different shades of certainty in the future simple tense. Let’s take a look at some examples:

- a. “I **will** go *if* he calls me.” (*Will* expresses a certainty.)
- b. “I **must** go *if* he calls me.” (*Must* expresses a personal obligation for the speaker.)
- c. “I **can** go *if* he calls me.” (*Can* expresses either permission from a third party or the fact that speaker is free from other commitments.)

Interrogative sentences (questions)

To form a question in the first conditional, we invert the subject with the modal auxiliary verb.

- a. "If I he calls me, **shall I go**?"
- b. "**Can I leave early** if Jake covers my shift?"
- c. "If I finish my homework on time, **may I go** to the party?"
- d. "If I come with you, **will you** buy me lunch?"

C) Second Conditional

We use the **second conditional** to speak about a hypothetical situation or outcome resulting from the condition. Unlike the first conditional, we use the second conditional to talk about things that cannot or are unlikely to happen. To create the second conditional, we use the **past simple tense** after the *if* clause, followed by *would* + the bare infinitive for the result of the condition. In addition to *would* (which we use to describe something we would definitely do), we can also use *could* for what we would be able to do, as well as *might* for what it is possible (but unlikely) we would do. For example:

- a. "If I went to London, I **would visit** Trafalgar Square."
- b. "If I won the lottery, I **could buy** a new house."
- c. "If you had a phone, you **could call** me every day."
- d. "If I was/were* older, I **might stay up** all night long."

(*Note that in more formal English, it is standard to use *were* in conditional sentences using the past tense of *be*, irrespective of it having a singular or plural subject. However, in everyday writing and speech, it is common to use *was* for singular subjects.) We can also put the second conditional in the negative to describe something that would not be the case if something else were also not the case. To form the negative, we use the negative of the past simple in the *if* clause, and make *would* negative in the clause describing the result of the condition. For example:

- a. "If our father **didn't work** so hard, we **wouldn't be able** to afford this house."
- b. "If I **didn't live** in London, I **could never speak** English so well."

Interrogative sentences (questions)

To form questions in the second conditional, we invert *would/could/might* with the subject.

For example:

- a. "If you had a million dollars, **would you buy** an expensive boat?"
- b. "**Would you travel** to South America if you spoke Spanish?"

We can also put a question word before *would* in this form:

- a. "**What would you do** if your family wasn't so wealthy?"
- b. "**Where might you go** if you won the lottery?"
- c. "If you could have dinner with a famous person, **who would you choose**?"

D) Third Conditional

Third conditionals are used to establish a hypothetical situation in the past, followed by a hypothetical outcome that did not really happen—typically, the outcome is the opposite of what actually happened. To form the third conditional, we use the **past perfect tense** for the *if* conditional clause, and *would have* + the **past participle** of the verb for the hypothetical outcome. (As with the second conditional, we can also use *could* or *might* instead of *would*. Additionally, we can use *should have* + the past participle to describe an outcome that ought to have happened.) For example:

- “If I **had been** more prepared, I **would have passed** that test.”

In reality, the speaker was not prepared, and so they did not pass the test. By creating a condition in the past using the past perfect tense, they can articulate how they might have achieved a different outcome if they were more prepared. Here are some other examples:

- Truth: “She was not there and couldn’t help you.”
- Conditional: “If she **had been** there, she **could have helped** you.”
- Truth: “I was late for work yesterday because I overslept.”
- Conditional: “If I **hadn’t overslept**, I **wouldn’t have been late** for work.”
- Truth: “You knew you had a test today.”
- Conditional: “If you **knew** you had a test today, you **should have studied** harder.”

Interrogative sentences (questions)

To form a question in the third conditional, we invert *would/could/might/should* with the subject and add a question word before it (if necessary). For example:

- a. “Would you have come to the party if you had known about it?”
- b. “What might you have done if you had known the truth?”
- c. “Where could you have gone if you hadn’t come here?”

3. Voices (Its Forms and Functions)

A) Active Voices

An active sentence is any declarative sentence constructed with S+V+O pattern. A passive sentence, on the contrary, is a sentence that is made with O+V+S pattern. In passive sentences, the receiver of the action is made to appear at the beginning of the sentence. Hence, there will be some changes on the verbs and tense markers.

Tense	Active sentence	Passive sentence	Grammatical Pattern of Passivation
Simple present	Hana makes the coffee.	The coffee is made by Hana.	is + V3
Present continuous	Hana is making the coffee.	The coffee is being made by Hana.	is + being + V3
Present perfect	Hana has made the coffee.	The coffee has been made by Hana.	Has + been+ V3
Simple past	Hana made the coffee yesterday.	The coffee was made by Hana yesterday.	Was + V3
Past continuous	Hana was making the coffee.	The coffee was being made by Hana.	Was+ being+V3
Past perfect	Hana had made the coffee.	The coffee had been made by Hana.	Had+ been + V3
Simple Future	Hana will make the coffee.	The coffee will be made by Hana.	Will + be + V3

A verb is in the **active voice** when the agent of the verb (the person or thing that performs the action specified by the verb) is also the subject of the sentence. The active voice is the most common type of voice in both spoken and written English, and is generally considered to be the **default voice**.

Not all active-voice verbs are required to take an *object*. Any object present, however, must come after the verb (which always comes after the agent). For example:

- "The boy **sang** a song." (with an object, *a song*)
- "I **am watching** a movie." (with an object, *a movie*)
- "Almaz **sings** well." (without an object)

✓ The **active voice** is a type of grammatical **voice** in which the *subject* of a sentence is also the **agent** of the verb—that is, it performs the action expressed by the verb. In active-voice sentences, the agent always comes before the verb. For example:

- "My friend **bought** a new car." (*My friend* performed the action *bought*.)
- "She **enjoys** watching movies." (*She* performs the action *enjoys*.)
- "Barney **is talking** to his sister." (*Barney* is performing the action *talking*.)

- ✓ A *direct object* is not always required for active-voice verbs. When an object is included, however, it must come directly after the verb. For example:
- “*I am drinking* some tea.” (with a direct object, *some tea*)
 - “*The boy hid* his report card from his parents.” (with a direct object, *his report card*)
 - “*Dr. Johnson will speak* at the convention.” (without a direct object)

I) When to use the active voice

Typically, the active voice is preferable to the **passive voice**, as it requires fewer words and expresses a clearer relationship between the verb and its agent. The active voice is generally thought of as the **default voice** in spoken and written English. The following sections contain circumstances in which you should always try to use the active voice over the passive voice.

2. When there is no direct object

Because passive-voice sentences require direct objects (which are turned into subjects when converted from active to passive voice), sentences without direct objects must be active. For example:

- “*That man has painted* for more than 40 years.”
- “*We departed* immediately after the grand finale.”
- “*The kids chatted* for several minutes.”

We can see how these sentences cannot be put in the passive voice, because there is no direct object to become the subject. Take, for instance, the first sentence:

- “For more than 40 years, **has been painted by the man.**” (What has been painted?)

It no longer makes any sense when structured in the passive voice, so it must remain active.

3. When the agent is important

The active voice is commonly used to emphasize the importance of an agent in a sentence. By using the active voice, we can highlight an agent’s *responsibility* for or *involvement* with a particular action. The examples below demonstrate the differences between an **important agent** (active voice) and an **unimportant agent** (passive voice):

- “*The employees drink* lots of coffee before work every day.” (active voice—describes the employees in relation to the act of drinking coffee)
- “Lots of coffee **is drunk by the employees** before work every day.” (passive voice—describes the act of drinking coffee in relation to the employees)
- “*Sir Isaac Newton discovered* gravity more than 300 years ago.” (active voice—emphasizes Newton’s responsibility for the discovery of gravity)
- “Gravity **was discovered by Sir Isaac Newton** more than 300 years ago.” (passive voice—emphasizes the discovery of gravity over Newton’s involvement)

4. When the agent is known or relevant

You should always use the active voice if an agent is identifiable or contains information that is relevant to the rest of the sentence. For example:

- “**Shawn stole** a menu from the restaurant.” (The speaker knows or is familiar with Shawn.)

- b. “A **veterinarian found** an abandoned puppy by the road.” (The speaker knows that it was a *veterinarian* who found the puppy and believes the information is relevant.)
- c. “**Dr. Li opened the hospital** in 1989.” (The speaker knows the name of the person who started the hospital and the information is relevant to the conversation.)

On the other hand, when an agent is unknown or irrelevant, we usually switch to the passive voice and eliminate the agent altogether. For example:

- a. “A menu **was stolen** from the restaurant.”
- b. “An abandoned puppy **was found** by the road.”
- c. “The hospital **was opened** in 1989.”

5. When expressing an authoritative tone

The active voice may also be used to stress the authority of an agent. This authoritative tone is a strategy commonly used in copywriting, advertising, and marketing in order to convince consumers of the beneficial effects of a product or service. It may also be used to establish a command or to more strongly emphasize an agent’s responsibility for an action. For example:

- a. “Brushing your teeth at least twice a day **is recommended by dentists**.” (passive voice)
- b. “*Dentists recommend* brushing your teeth at least twice a day.” (active voice—emphasizes the authority of the *dentists*)
- c. “All of your broccoli **must be eaten by you** before dessert is served.” (passive voice)
- d. “*You must eat* all of your broccoli before dessert is served.” (active voice—emphasizes your responsibility to eat your broccoli)

6. When the agent is an ongoing topic

Agents that can perform multiple actions may be treated as **topics**. Making an agent an ongoing topic places emphasis on that agent instead of the actions it performs. When an agent acts as a topic, it usually remains the primary *subject* in most active-voice sentences used to describe or refer to it. This can be seen most prominently in works of fiction, in which protagonists typically perform numerous actions throughout a story. For example, look at how the passage below describes a fictional protagonist named Caroline:

- ✓ “*Caroline jumped* back and gasped. *She was* afraid of spiders and **despised** the feeling of their silky webs on her skin. But *she knew* it was time to face her fears. Sighing and brushing herself off, *Caroline* slowly **continued** down the path toward the hill.”

B) Passive voice (Its Forms and Functions)

A sentence uses the **passive voice** when the subject is acted upon by the verb. Passive-voice sentences are structurally opposite to active-voice sentences, with the object (now the subject* of the sentence) coming before the verb and the verb coming before the agent of the action. A passive-voice verb is used in the past participle form preceded by the auxiliary verb *be*, and the preposition *by* is inserted before the agent to form a **prepositional phrase**. For example:

- a. “*Angie* **will perform** a famous piano piece tomorrow night.” (active voice)
 - b. “A famous piano piece **will be performed** *by Angie* tomorrow night.” (passive voice)
 - c. “*Thousands of people* **have already read** his new book.” (active voice)
 - d. “His new book **has already been read** *by thousands of people*.” (passive voice)
- ✓ (*When converting a sentence from active to passive, the original *object* becomes the new *subject* due to its position at the beginning of the sentence. At the same time, the *agent* changes into the object of a *prepositional phrase*.)
- ✓ Unlike active-voice, passive-voice sentences **do not** require agents. If an agent is unknown or irrelevant, you may eliminate the prepositional phrase containing the agent. For example:
- a. “The light bulb was patented **by Thomas Edison** in 1880.” (with agent)
 - b. “The light bulb was patented in 1880.” (without agent)
 - c. “The wedding venue has been decided on **by the bride and groom**.” (with agent)
 - d. “The wedding venue has been decided on.” (without agent)
- ✓ The **passive voice** is a type of grammatical **voice** in which the *subject* is acted upon by the *verb*. In passive-voice sentences, the subject is the **receiver of the action** (i.e., what would be the *direct object* in an **active-voice** sentence). For example:
- a. “The concert **was attended** by many young people.” (The subject *the concert* receives the action of *attended*.)
 - b. “The necklace **is being made** by a child.” (The subject *the necklace* receives the action of *being made*.)
- ✓ Passive-voice verbs are always preceded by the auxiliary verb *be* and are in their **past participle** forms. While the receiver of the action comes before the verb, the person or thing performing the action (known as the *agent*) comes after the verb and is preceded by the preposition *by* to form a **prepositional phrase**. For example:
- a. “The lights **were turned off** *by the janitor*.” (*The lights* is the subject, but *the janitor* performs the action *turned off*.)
 - b. “Final exams **will be taken** *by students* on Friday.” (*Final exams* is the subject, but *students* performs the action *taken*.)
 - c. “Letters to Santa **are sent** *by children* every year.” (*Letters to Santa* is the subject, but *children* performs the action *sent*.)

I) Converting the active voice into the passive voice

- ✓ You may only convert a sentence from the active voice into the passive voice if there is a **direct object**. As we've seen, this direct object becomes the *subject* in the passive voice. For example:
 - a. "A high school track and field star **won** the race." (active voice)
 - b. "The race **was won** by a high school track and field star." (passive voice)
 - c. "Local businesses **are handing out** pamphlets near the mall." (active voice)
 - d. "Pamphlets **are being handed out** by local businesses near the mall." (passive voice)
- ✓ If an active-voice sentence does **not** contain a direct object, it **cannot** be converted into the passive voice, as the sentence will lack coherency without a subject. For example:
 - a. "The kids **are playing** outside." (active voice)
 - b. "**Is being played** by the kids outside." (**What** is being played by the kids?)

II) Converting the passive voice into the active voice

- ✓ You may only convert a sentence from the passive voice into the active voice if there is an identifiable **agent** of the verb. In the active voice, this agent becomes the *subject*. For example:
 - b. "This blanket **was knitted** by my grandmother." (passive voice)
 - c. "My grandmother **knitted** this blanket." (active voice)
 - d. "The deer **was being chased** by a bear." (passive voice)
 - e. "A bear **was chasing** the deer." (active voice)
- ✓ If a passive-voice sentence does **not** contain an agent, it **cannot** be converted into the active voice, as the sentence will lack coherency without a subject. For example:
 - a. "The Great Pyramid of Giza **was constructed** more than 4,000 years ago." (passive voice)
 - b. "**Constructed** the Great Pyramid of Giza more than 4,000 years ago." (**Who** constructed the Great Pyramid of Giza?)

III) When to use the passive voice

The passive voice is less commonly used than the active voice because it is wordy and often lacks clarity; however, there are several cases in which using the passive voice may be necessary or preferable. The following sections contain various circumstances in which you might wish to use the passive voice instead of the active voice.

1. When the receiver of the action is important

The passive voice may be used to emphasize the importance of the receiver of the action. (In contrast, the active voice typically emphasizes the importance of the *agent*.) The examples below demonstrate the differences between an **important receiver of the action** (passive voice) and an **important agent** (active voice):

- a. "The school dance **will be organized** by the science teachers this year." (passive voice—emphasizes the *activity* in relation to the organizers)

- b. “The science teachers **will organize** the school dance this year.” (active voice— emphasizes the *organizers* in relation to the activity)
- c. “She **is always being praised** by her parents.” (passive voice—emphasizes *she* in relation to her parents)
- d. “Her parents **are always praising** her*.” (active voice—emphasizes *her parents* in relation to her) (*When the pronoun *she* is converted into an object, it becomes *her*.)

2. When the agent is unknown, irrelevant, or implied

Occasionally, the agent of an action may be unknown or irrelevant to the rest of a sentence, or it may already be heavily implied through the action or receiver of the action. In these cases, the agent may be eliminated altogether (which can only be done with the passive voice—**not** the active voice). For example:

- a. “My missing wallet **was returned** to a lost-and-found.” (unknown agent—we don’t know who returned the missing wallet)
- b. “A popular play **is being performed** at the local theater.” (irrelevant agent—the names of the performers are irrelevant)
- c. “Bathing suits **are usually sold** in the summer months.” (implied agent—we can assume that the agent is *clothing stores* or something similar)

3. When softening an authoritative tone

Because the passive voice places less emphasis on the *responsibility of the agent* and more emphasis on the *receiver of the action*, we can use the passive voice to express commands in a softer, less authoritative tone than those expressed through the active voice. For example:

- a. “*Inexperienced mountaineers* **should not attempt** Mount Everest.” (active voice— emphasizes inexperienced mountaineers’ responsibility to avoid the mountain)
- b. “Mount Everest **should not be attempted** by *inexperienced mountaineers*.” (passive voice—emphasizes the difficulty or danger of the mountain)

If the agent is clearly implied, it may be eliminated for the sake of conciseness:

- a. “*You* **need to finish** this project by tomorrow.” (active voice)
- b. “This project **needs to be finished** by *you* by tomorrow.” (passive voice with agent)
- c. “This project **needs to be finished** by tomorrow.” (passive voice without agent)

4. When expressing a professional, neutral, or objective tone

Various forms of writing, including scientific reports and instruction manuals, use the passive voice to express a professional, neutral, or objective tone. Typically, the receiver of the action functions as the primary **topic** throughout the text. The agent is usually removed due to irrelevance or to avoid a sense of subjectivity. For example:

- a. “The experiment **was conducted** over the course of two weeks.”
- b. “Once Part A **has been inserted** into Part B, tighten the screws with a screwdriver.”
- c. “Adverse reactions to the medication **should be assessed and treated** by a *medical professional*.”

Session Two: Reading Comprehension Skills

Comprehending what you read is more than just recognizing and understanding words. True comprehension means making sense of what you read and connecting the ideas in the text to what you already know. It also means remembering what you have read. In other words, comprehending means thinking while you read. In this session, you will practice some important reading comprehension skills and you will learn to think in new ways about what you are reading.

The reading comprehension passages usually includes questions that test learners the ability to find the main idea or a suitable title for the text, find information directly specified in the passage, draw inferences from the passage given, determine the meaning of strange words used in the passage, determine the author's style, mood or point of view.

A. Identifying best title or main idea

A good paragraph generally has one central thought—a thought is generally stated in one sentence. That sentence, the topic sentence, may appear anywhere in the paragraph (although we are accustomed to look for it in the opening or closing sentences). However, these days, topic sentences are often implied than stated in the passage. A good title for a passage of two or more paragraphs should include the thought of all the paragraphs. The central thought thus is the one around which the author tries to build up the whole text. Usually, questions of this type take the following forms:

- *The main idea of the passage may be best expressed as*
- *The author wants to say in this paragraph*
- *The theme of the text is*
- *A suitable title for the paragraph would be*

The tips to find out central thought/theme of the text are:

1. Decide on the subject that is being taken up in the text. It can be person, place, thing or some idea or concept.
2. Look for the most important thing being said about the subject of the text. You will find that either the subject is doing something or something is being done to the subject. This action then becomes the verb to the headline that will lead you to the title of the paragraph.

3. Look out for words that you feel are significant to the subject of the text. Then, there are words like ‘after all’, ‘most important’, ‘obviously’, ‘significantly’, which point to elements of greater value.
4. Find out words that are likely to be important in interpreting questions, answers, and the passage itself—words like ‘always’, ‘never’, ‘mostly’, ‘ever’, ‘exactly’, ‘precisely’, ‘possible’, ‘definite’, ‘impossible’, ‘unless’, ‘all’, ‘no’, ‘least’, ‘without’, ‘entire’ etc.

B. Answering questions asking for specific information

The answers to such questions are in the text. You must be able to find a word, a sentence or a group of sentences that justify the choice. You must not call on information in other sources. You must not let yourself be hurried into making unfounded assumptions. These questions often take the following forms:

- *As per the text, which of the following statements is correct*
- *The author states that*
- *The passage includes all the items listed below, except*

C. Answering inference questions

These type of questions are the most difficult since you are to draw an answer not stated clearly in the text. This increases the probability of error, but by grasping the author’s ideas you should be able to reject inferences that cannot be made. These questions take the following forms:

- *The passage is intended to*
- *It may be inferred from the text that*
- *The author probably feels that*

The tips to draw correct inference are:

1. Give a reason for your choice as well as rejection—if A is true, B must also be true.
2. Grasp the author’s idea—how he feels about the subject.
3. Figure out whether the passage is part of an argument, a description, or part of a longer story.

You will find out that you are choosing the answer according to the minutes of the author.

D. Answering vocabulary questions

The purpose of this kind of question is to determine how well you can extract the meaning from the text; it is not to test how extensive your vocabulary is. Don’t assume that you know the meaning of the word. You must find out the meaning of the word as used in the text. You must look within the text for clues, as often clues are given within the same sentence or near it. Therefore, the points to be remembered are:

1. Sometimes, the word is common but is used in a special or technical way.
2. Sometimes, a word may be completely new. The near-by words and proper punctuation will provide you with clues (Many a time the antonym of the word is given somewhere in the passage.)
3. The unknown word asked bears a deceptive resemblance to a known word which is also present in the choices.
4. Sometimes, the meaning of the word is given before it is used or the entire text describes a concept or a situation, which is the definition of the word.

E. Answering question on author's style or mood

Some questions will ask you to identify the mood, style of the author or his/her approach to the subject. Such questions are usually asked last. Your response to such questions should be based upon an overall understanding of the text rather than by bits of evidence. So, the tips to evaluate or determine author's style are:

1. Words like 'according to', 'finally', 'therefore', 'hence' will lead you to the cause-and-effect relationship being carried out on the subject.
2. Words such as 'but', 'still', 'otherwise', 'however', 'yet' indicate the comparison or contrast being made with the subject.
3. Words like 'beware of', 'although', 'note that', 'importantly' call attention to the important ideas being discussed by the author.
4. Sometimes, words like 'although', 'of', 'instead of' signal a change of direction, that is, towards a new thought, but it is not necessary that a comparison is made out or a cause-effect relationship is touched.

Time Saving Tactics /Techniques/ in Reading Passage

For tackling comprehension passages, you have to train your eyes and mind to function simultaneously. As your mind begins to look for ideas rather than words, your eyes will begin to obey your mind. They will skim over words, looking for ideas your mind is telling them to search for. Good reading is good thinking—and a good thinker will be a good reader.

Speed in reading and comprehension work together. Therefore, do not be afraid if you come across difficult words in the passage. Your task is to look for ideas or what the author wants to convey. The following approach has been used with great success in tackling comprehension questions.

Step 1: Glance through the questions quickly

Instead of reading the passage first, it is better to skim over the questions that are given at the end of the passage. This will help you determine what you have to look for while reading the passage. As stated earlier, your mind will begin to search for ideas. But do not spend too much time on looking at the questions. The purpose of step 1 is to give you an idea of what you should be looking for in the passage.

Step 2: Read the passage as fast as you can

Read the passage without worrying about full comprehension, but keep in mind the questions that you have read in step 1. If you come across material that seems relevant to any of the questions, underline that portion with a pencil. The purpose of step 2 is to let you get an overview of the passage and to familiarize you with the relative position, of key words, key facts, and key ideas in the passage. It is also advisable to mark the question number in the margin of the passage alongside the relevant part, and circle your provisional answer choice under the question.

Step 3: Re-read the questions for proper comprehension

Now, carefully read the question. If you are able to recollect its location in the passage, mark the answer in your answer book. If you fail to recollect the location of the relevant material in the passage, go on to the next question. This step will help you answer the easy questions before concentrating on the more taxing ones in the next step.

Step 4: Re-read the passage for comprehension

Now, re-read the passage at a comfortable pace for comprehension. While reading, keep the unanswered questions in mind, and follow the same process as in step 2. If you find relevant material to correctly answer a question, mark the question number in the margin of the passage and encircle the provisional answer choice as you did in step 2.

Step 5: Re-read questions that are still unanswered

These questions may be more taxing. Go back to the passage once again very quickly and find the relevant material from the passage by concentrating only on the particular information that is required to answer the question. Note: At the outset, this approach may seem quite time consuming. However, with some practice you will find it simple and faster than the traditional method of going through the passage straightaway without reading the questions first, as suggested here.

Sample Passage and Questions

Read the following passage and answer the questions given below it. Note the words italicized in the passage and try to understand their meanings in the context of the passage and answer the questions given below it.

On August 15, 1947, India was granted independence from British colonial *dominance*. This was an event of international significance. From this day onwards, the Indian Union assumed a role in world politics that was appropriate enough to modify the thinking of nations. *Concepts* like *non-alignment*, tolerance, non-violence and peaceful *coexistence* were introduced by India into the international vocabulary.

“Our dreams concern India”, said the first Prime Minister of the country, Pt Jawaharlal Nehru, on the eve of achieving freedom, “but they also concern the whole world, for the world has become one”.

Mahatma Gandhi chose Nehru to become the first PM of independent India. With his vision of unity of the nation, he became the architect of modern India. It was to be a federal state based on *secularism*—the commitment to an Indian identity, which was above all races, castes, and religions. It was a vision of extraordinary *dimensions*.

Both Nehru as well as his daughter and successor, Smt Indira Gandhi, were well aware that only a firm *anchorage* in the Indian identity could unite the nation and enable it to make an impact on the world. In these days of mutual interdependence, the western powers and America cannot afford to ignore what is happening in this region. It is possible that the fate of the Asian democracies would one day be decided on the banks of the Ganges. If India fails to remain a democracy, this would *trigger* the fall of the whole of South and South-east Asia. That is why the Indian Prime Minister has to play a role that goes well beyond duties related to internal affairs only. It is of international political significance.

I. Based on the information in the passage, choose the best answer for the following questions.

1. What made Pt Jawaharlal Nehru the architect of modern India?
A. He secured independence for India C. He wanted India to make an impact on the world
B. Because he was the first Prime Minister of India D. His vision of the unity of the nation
2. Which of the following concepts have been introduced by India into the international vocabulary?
A. Mutual interdependence and democracy C. Non-alignment and tolerance
B. Non-violence and peaceful co-existence D. All of the above

3. Which word in this passage is used to describe the phrase “to live together with mutual tolerance”?
 A. non-alignment B. coexistence C. secularism D. anchorage
4. Which among the following words best describes the meaning of the word ‘trigger’ used in the passage?
 A. to set in action B. to become uncontrollable C. to become inactive D. aggravate
5. Select from the answer choices, the word that is synonymous to ‘Dimensions’.
 A. support B. size C. importance D. height
6. Which of the following words can be used to replace the word ‘repercussion’, used in the passage, without altering the meaning of the writer?
 A. impression B. reaction C. suppression D. alteration
7. Why does the role of the Indian Prime Minister go beyond the duties related to internal affairs of the country?
 A. To create an impact on foreign countries
 B. Because happenings in India influence politics and democracies of South and South-east Asia
 C. To avoid interference of America and other big powers
 D. None of these
8. Select the word that is as nearly opposite in meaning to ‘dominance’ used in this passage.
 A. government B. rule C. subordination D. importance

Session Three : Building Vocabulary Using Its Learning Strategies

It is said that star athletes do not win important events unless they have been trained rigorously. Great musicians practice continuously to prepare for important concerts. Similarly, train yourself beforehand to deal with all types of vocabulary questions that may appear in the national examination.

Good reading comprehension depends on understanding the words you are reading. The more words you recognize and understand in a text, the better your comprehension will be. The first step towards successfully answering any test question is understanding what is being asked in the question. It is a good idea to familiarize yourself beforehand with the general nature of the directions for each type of question. However, no matter how familiar you are with the directions, be sure to read them carefully at the time you take the test in order to be sure that no changes have been made. Thus, in this session you will learn and practice important strategies for building your vocabulary.

A) Using Lists of Synonyms and Antonyms in English Language

The following is a list of common words along with their synonyms (words with more or less similar meaning) and antonyms (words with more or less opposite meaning) to help you tackle the vocabulary section of synonyms and antonyms in your examination:

Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
Abandon	forsake, leave, give up, relinquish	retain, stay with
Abase	humiliate, disgrace, bring down, humble	exalt, uplift, honour
Abash	confuse, feel or made to feel ashamed, confound	encourage, cheer to
Abate	lessen, reduce, diminish, decline	raise, increase, rise, augment
Abet	help, assist, encourage	discourage, hinder, block
abhor	dislike, detest, hate	approve, like
abject	degraded, mean, grovelling, wretched or miserable	proud, independent
abnormal	unusual, irregular, unnatural	normal, usual, regular
abjure	disclaim, forswear, repudiate, disavow	accept, claim, avow
aboriginal	native, indigenous	immigrant, imported
abortive	futile, unsuccessful, fruitless, miscarriage of birth	successful, effective, well-timed
abridge	condense, summarise, shorten, curtail	expand, extend, enlarge
abrupt	sudden, steep, hasty	gentle, gently, sloping
abscond	decamp, run away, go away secretly	remain, stay, live in
absolve	acquit, release, pardon, set free from guilt	condemn, sentence
abstain	refrain, desist, forbear	continue, permit
abstruse	hidden, obscure, deep	simple, open, revealed
abundant	ample, plentiful, rich, exuberant	meagre, inadequate, poor, insufficient
abuse	injure, maltreat, revile, upbraid	praise, use well
accede	consent, assent, comply	refuse, resign, quit
accelerate	hasten, expedite, quicken	retard, hinder, reduce speed
accession	addition, enlargement, extension	diminution, loss
accommodate	suit, reconcile, oblige	refuse, disoblige
accomplish	finish, fulfil, execute, achieve	fail, leave undone
accord	agreement, harmony, willingness	discord, disagreement, unwillingness
accredited	authorised, entrusted, delegated	discredited, unauthorised
accumulate	collect, pile up, store	squander, waste, distribute
acquaintance	knowledge, cognisance	ignorance, unfamiliar
acute	sharp, penetrating	dull, blunt
addicted	devoted, accustomed to	unaddicted, free
adept	skillful, expert	clumsy, not expert/inexpert
adhere	stick, abide by, cling	break from, come undone
adjacent	close, near, contiguous	remote, distant, far away
adjourn	postpone, defer, delay, put off, suspend	advance, hurry on schedule
adoration	worship, reverence, beautify	irreverence, contempt, disfiguring,

affinity	alliance, liking, sympathy, attraction	marring dislike, discord, antipathy, repulsion, repugnance
aggravate	intensify, make worse	diminish, reduce, please, satisfy
alienate	estrangle, transfer, desolation	reconcile, recover
alienation	desolation, disaffection	allegiance, camaraderie, companionship, fellowship
allegiance	loyalty, fidelity, fealty	disloyalty, treachery, disaffection, rebellion
alleviate	lessen, lighten, reduce	enlarge, escalate, heighten

Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
alliance	union, combination, league, confederation	separation, opposition, disunion, division
altercation	quarrel, dispute, discord, friction, strife	agreement, consensus
ambiguous	doubtful, uncertain, suspicion, scepticism	clear, simple, certainty, confidence
ameliorate	improve, amend, meliorate	worsen, spoil, impair, deteriorate
amiable	lovable, charming, agreeable, affable	unlovable, unattractive
amicable	friendly, cordial, in goodwill	unfriendly, cold
analogy	likeness, resemblance, comparison	difference, dissimilar
annihilate	destroy, abolish, nullify, wipe out, reduce	restore, ratify, improve
annul	cancel, quash, nullify	ratify, restore
antagonistic	opposed, adverse, hostile, rival	friendly, sympathetic, associated
anticipate	forestall, forecast, prejudge, foresee	be missed
antipathy	dislike, aversion, hostility	liking, sympathy, attachment
antique	ancient, old, hoary, immemorial	modern, fresh, new, young, recent, novel
apparent	clear, evident, plain, conspicuous, manifest, obvious	obscure, invisible, concealed, hidden, secret, implicit, inconspicuous
appease	assuage, pacify, lessen, alleviate, lighten	provoke, vex, enlarge, escalate, extend, heighten
applaud	cheer, approve	cry down, hiss
applause	acclaim, acclamation, plaudit	abuse, disapproval, jeering, booing, censure
apposite	pertinent, relevant, apt	irrelevant, inapposite
apprise	inform, acquaint, notify, advise, enlighten	keep secret, misinform
apprehend	grasp, seize, arrest, perceive, fear	miss, relax, let go, misunderstand
approbation	approval, sanction, commendation	disapproval, censure, dissatisfaction
arbitrary	tyrannical, dictatorial, absolute, imperious	reasonable, mild, constitutional
arduous	difficult, laborious	easy, light, simple
ardent	fiery, heated, hot, passionate, fervent, impassioned, zealous	calm, cool, impassive
arrogant	haughty, indolent, overbearing, imperious	humble, tolerant, modest, docile, obsequious
ascendancy	superiority, mastery, upper hand	inferiority, subjection
assail	attack, assault, storm, besiege, charge	defend, protect, uphold
assuage	calm, tranquilize, lessen, alleviate, lighten, allay	excite, disturb, enlarge, escalate, extend, heighten, toughen
atonement	reconciliation, amends, propitiation	derange, misfit, disjoin, dislocate, disarrange
audacious	bold, daring, disdainful, insolent, scornful	timid, shrinking, considerate, humble, polite, respectful

augment	increase, enlarge, swell, extend	decrease, lessen, reduce
authentic	true, certain, genuine, veritable	unauthentic, spurious
auspicious	lucky, favourable	unfavourable, unlucky
avenge	retaliate, punish	forgive, pardon, overlook
aversion	hostility, dislike, unwillingness, distaste	willingness, readiness, liking
avocation	recreation, employment of leisure	vocation, business
awful	venerable, solemn, dreadful, shocking	secular, unimpressive, pleasant
awkward	clumsy, unhandy, rude, clownish, ungainly	handy, clever, graceful, refined
Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
baffle	defeat, puzzle, confuse, perplex, mystify	clarify, inform, easy
barbarous	uncivilised, cruel	civilised, gentle
bare	naked, nude, stripped	clothed, covered, dressed
barricade	obstacle, barrier, hurdle	help, open, approachable
beguile	deceive, cheat	enlighten, treat, honesty
belittle	depreciate, deprecate, discredit, disparage, minimise	credit, encourage, enhance, exaggerate
benevolent	charitable, benign, kind, generous, unselfish	malevolent, uncharitable, malice, stingy, egoistic, merciless
betray	disclose, divulge, deceive, treacher,	conceal, defend, be loyal
bewilder	puzzle, perplex, confuse	enlighten, illuminate
binding	compulsory, obligatory	voluntary, laxative
biased	one-sided, partial, partisan, prejudiced, slanted, subjective	disinterested, open-minded unbiased
bigotry	bias, intolerance, narrow-mindedness	impartiality, objectivity, tolerance, open-mindedness
blandishment	flattery, coaxing	bluntness, disrespect
blasphemy	profanity, swearing, cursing, obscenity, vulgarity, obscene	reverence, exquisite, polite
blatant	noisy, vociferous, clamorous	quiet, gentle, soothing
bleak	cold, cheerless, barren, desolate, weak	warm, comfortable, luxurious, healthy
bliss	happiness, delight	unhappiness, misery
bloom	freshness, flush	decay, withered state
boggle	falter, doubt, waver, shrink, demur, shirk	be certain, act promptly, consent, accede
boisterous	loud, blatant, noisy, clamorous, vociferous	quiet, calm, soft, silent, disciplined, tranquil
bombastic	turgid, fustian	simple, quiet, brief, sober speech
brandish	flourish, swing, wield	arrest, hang, suspend
brashness	brass, cheek, gall, hide, nerve	civility, meekness, politeness
brevity	shortness, conciseness, succinctness, summarized	lengthy, longwindedness, circumlocution
brutal	cruel, rough, beast-like	human, kindly, gentle
brusque	abrupt, rude, blunt, bluff, curt, gruff, surly	diplomatic, gracious, mannerly, urbane
by stander	looker-on, onlooker, spectator, beholder	performer, actor
candid	fair, impartial, just, frank, ingenuous	unfair, partial, biased, disingenuous
canvass	investigate, scrutinise, inspect, solicit	leave alone, refuse
caprice	freak, whim, fancy, vagary	Steadfastness
captivity	bondage, servitude	freedom, liberty

catastrophe	calamity, debacle, disaster, cataclysm	benefit, blessing, boon, comfort, success
caress	fondle, hug, embrace	repel, discourage
cease	leave off, stop, desist	begin, continue
cede	give up, surrender, yield, relinquish	hold, refuse
celebrated	famous, notable, renowned, glorious, eminent	unknown, undistinguished
censure	blame, condemn, rebuke, admonish, reprimand	praise, commend, endorse
ceremonious	formal, solemn, courtly, ritual	unceremonious, informal, undignified, haphazard

Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
cessation	ending, pause, rest, ceasing, intermission, discontinuance	beginning, continuance
cheer	gladden, encourage, exhilarate, refresh	chill, depress, dispirit, ridicule, sadden, disheartened
cherish	nourish, foster, entertain, harbour	neglect, repel
chivalrous	heroic, brave	cowardly, ungallant
circumlocution	euphemism, euphuism, indirectness, periphrasis	brevity, conciseness, condensation, directness, succinctness
circumscribe	bound, contain, encircle, enclose, encompass, surround	open, unbound
clamour	outcry, uproar	silence, peace
clemency	gentleness, mildness, mercy, leniency	harshness, severity
coalition	alliance, combination	disunion, separation
coarse	rough, gross, thick, rude, vulgar	thin, fine, refined
coerce	compel, force, subdue, oblige, constrain	persuade, lead, free, cooperate, coincide, collaborate
collateral	indirect, not lineal, confirmatory	lineal, direct
colossal	gigantic, huge, large	small, diminutive
combat	struggle, fight, encounter	peace, rest
commensurate	equal, equivalent, tantamount, synonymous	unequal, incommensurate, opposed, antonymous
commodious	convenient, roomy	cramped, incommodious
compassion	pity, sympathy	ruthlessness, antipathy
comprehend	comprise, embrace, understand, perceive	exclude, fail to perceive
comprehensive	inclusive, extensive	exclusive, narrow
compress	squeeze, contract	loosen, expand
conceal	hide, cover, keep secret	reveal, disclose
concede	allow, permit, yield	forbid, deny, unyielding
concise	short, brief, succinct	diffuse, lengthy, large
concord	agreement, accord	disagreement, discord
condemn	blame, censure, disapprove	praise, approve
confer	give, bestow, award, accord, grant	refuse, take back, withdraw, withhold
conjure	adjure, implore, beckon, invoke, beseech	command, injunction
conscientious	exact, honourable, meticulous, punctilious	unprincipled, dishonourable
considerate	thoughtful, unselfish	thoughtless, selfish

consign	deposit, commit, deliver	withhold, withdraw
conspicuous	noticeable, remarkable	insignificant, obscure
conspiracy	plot, combination, league, intrigue	Counterplot
contend	strive, struggle, compete	yield, give in
contemptible	despicable, detestable, execrable	admirable, excellent, moral
contemptuous	audacious, disdainful, insolent, scornful, supercilious	considerate, humble, polite, respectful, reverent
contradict	contravene, deny, oppose, controvert, disprove, refute	affirm, agree, corroborate, maintain, uphold
Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
contradictory	conflicting, contrary, opposite, opposed	accordant, agreeing, compatible, concordant, consistent, harmonious
contravene	contradict, interfere, oppose, refute, counteract	stand aside, assist, affirm, corroborate
corroborate	strengthen, establish	weaken, disapprove
coruscate	flash, glitter, gleam	flame, burn steadily
countenance	favour, sanction, approve	discountenance, disapprove, forbid
counterfeit	forged, spurious, shoddy, snide, apocryphal	accurate, authentic, genuine, sincere
crafty	cunning, artful	ingenuous, honest
cripple	lame, disable, weak, hobbled, gammy, halt	help, strengthen
cruel	brutal, bestial, nasty, sadistic	gentle, humane, kind, merciful
culmination	summit, zenith, top	bottom, base
cursory	transient, rapid, careless, hasty, scant	leisurely, thorough, careful, minute, profound
danger	hazard, jeopardy, menace, peril, risk, threat	defence, protection, safety, security, safeguard
daring	adventurous, venturesome	timid, cautious, cowardly
dainty	delicious, palatable, nice, delicate, neat	unpalatable, inelegant, uncritical
dash	hurl, cast, smash, destroy, abash, rush	retain, encourage, standstill
daunt	dismay, terrify, scare	encourage, cheer
dawdle	procrastinate, dally, dilly-dally, loiter	decide, persevere, push on, quicken
debar	hinder, exclude, prevent, shut out	facilitate, admit, allow
debase	degrade, humiliate, disgrace, humble, demean, downgrade	exalt, purify, praise, respect, compliment
debility	weakness, infirmity	strength, health
declare	advertise, announce, enunciate, proclaim	ensor, conceal, withhold
decrease	abate, decline, drop, fall, sink, subside	climb, enlarge, escalate, grow, strengthen, wax
decorum	propriety, decency, gravity, staidness	impropriety, lack of dignity, levity
deface	disfigure, damage	improve, preserve
defame	malign, asperse, libel, slander, vilify	praise, commendation
deference	respect, reverence, honour, homage	disrespect, rudeness
defile	corrupt, soil, stain, contaminate	cleanse, purify
deformity	malformation, ugliness, disfigurement, blemish, defacement	shapely, adorn, beautify, con-serve, restore
defray	discharge, liquidate, settle	be in debt
defraud	cheat, fleece, swindle	honest, sincere
deleterious	harmful, deadly, killing	harmless, innocuous

delusion	fantasy, illusion, mirage, hallucination	actuality, fact, reality, truth, verify
demur	pause, stop, hesitate, recoil, shirk, shy	agree, act promptly, accept, consent, accede
depose	dethrone, degrade	enthroned, exalt
depraved	corrupt, degenerate, evil, heinous, infamous, nefarious, vile, wicked	honest, innocent, moral, pious, chaste
descend	decline, drop, fall, sink	climb, increase, lift, soar
desert	abandon, run away	stay with, retain
Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
desecration	debasement, defilement, profanation, sacrilege, violation	consecration, purification, sanctification
despair	dejection, depression, desperation, hopelessness	confidence, encouragement, expectation, hope, optimism
desist	leave off, stop	continue, go on
despotic	unconstitutional, arbitrary, autocratic, dictatorial, tyrannical	constitutional, reasonable, democratic, lawful, representative
destitute	wanting, needy, poor	well-provided, well-to-do
desultory	rambling, casual, random	steady, straightforward, orderly, systematic
deteriorate	lower, spoil, decline	ameliorate, improve
devoid	empty, vacant	full, well, supplied
devout	religious, pious	irreligious, profane
dexterity	skill, facility	clumsiness, not skilled
diffident	hesitating, doubtful	confident, trusting
dilapidated	ruined, wasted	restored, in repair
dilate	expand, widen, broaden	contract, narrow, squeeze
diligence	industrious, care	laziness, slackness
discern	perceive, descry	misunderstand, confuse
disconsolate	sad, cheerless, disturb	happy, cheerful, glad
disgrace	abase, debase, degrade, demean, downgrade, humble	compliment, exalt, praise, raise, respect
disinterested	fair, impartial, unbiased, objective	interested, biased, partial, subjective
disown	disclaim, deny	acknowledge, accept
disseminate	spread, scatter, disperse, broadcast, diffuse	withhold, withdraw, unite, gather
dogmatic	authoritative	undogmatic, vague
dreadful	awful, appalling, ugly	harmless, pleasing, soothing
dress	apparel, attire, costume, garb, gear	undress, unclothed
dwell	reside, abide, live	travel, move on
dwindle	decrease, shrink, decline, reduce	increase, grow, expand, extend
eager	avid, desirous, intent, enthusiastic, keen	impassive, indifferent, listless, uninterested, uninvolved
earnest	eager, ardent	slack, apathetic
eccentric	irregular, anomalous	concentric, regular
eccentricity	idiosyncrasy, oddity, quirk	commonness, normality, ordinariness, conventionality
eclipse	overshadow, dim, obscure	reveal, illumine
ecstasy	rapture, transport	calmness, agony, displeasure
edible	eatable, harmless	uneatable, inedible

efficacy	force, energy, virtue, potency, competency	weakness, impotence, incompetency
elegant	graceful, refined, deluxe, elaborate, luxurious, sumptuous	inexpensive, ungraceful, unrefined, mediocre, simple, unadorned, usual, vulgar
embarrass	confuse, entangle	help, enable
Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
embarrassment	chagrin, shame, humiliation, discomposure, mortification	brashness, composure, confidence, contentment, exaltation, temerity
embezzle	steal, flich	be honest, sincere
embrace	incorporate, embody	exclude, keep away
emotion	affect, desire, feeling, passion, sentiment	indifference, reason, insensibility, rationality
encroach	intrude, trespass, infringe, invade, violate	keep away from, desist, withdraw, respect
endorse	approve, sanction, back, confirm, ratify, condemn, okay	disapprove, oppose, censure, reject, reprehend
endow	dower, furnish, bequest	deprive, withhold
endurance	continuance, persist, withstand, sustain	cessation, forgo, relinquish, submit, bear, cope, put up with
enormous	colossal, gigantic, large	small, puny, compact
ensue	follow, succeed	go before, cause
entangle	involve, implicate, ravel	unravel, free, clear
entice	allure, attract, yield	repel, repulse, resist
entrap	entangle, ensnare	set free, liberate
envy	jealousy, ill-will	goodwill, contentedness
espouse	betroth, marry, support	refuse, oppose, resist
escalate	increase, intensify, step up	decrease, lessen, reduce, weaken
escape	abscond, flee, fly, retreat, run away	confront, face, follow, remain, submit, surrender
eternal	endless, everlasting, permanent	transient, temporary, non-permanent
evasive	shuffling, equivocal	frank, honest, sincere
everlasting	endless, eternal, timeless, interminable, never-ending, unending	finite, temporary
exaggerate	amplify, magnify	minimise, understate
exalt	lift up, raise, elevate	cast down, lower
excel	surpass, superior	fail, inferior
exclaim	call out	be silent, quiet
exhale	breath out, evaporate, eject, reject, vomit	inhale, intake, assimilate
exile	banish, expulsion, expatriation, deport, relegate, rusticate	repatriation, welcome, greet
expatriate	exile, expel, foreigner	repatriate, recall
exonerate	absolve, acquit, vindicate, exculpate	accuse, implicate
explicit	express, definite	implicit, vague
exquisite	delicate, fine, graceful, polished, refined	clumsy, unrefined, common, coarse, rough
extenuate	lessen, reduce, decrease, decline	heighten, intensify, enhance, exaggerate
extinguish	quench, annihilate	light, kindle
extraneous	foreign, extrinsic, immaterial, inessential	native, intrinsic, relevant, significant
extricate	emancipate, free	enslave, bind

fabulous	false, not real, fictitious, mythical	true, real, actual, based on facts
facetious	merry, jesting	dull, serious
fallacy	deception, illusion	truth, real
fantastic	fanciful, imaginative, queer	real, practical
Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
fastidious	particular, meticulous	indifferent, careless
feeble	weak, debilitated, frail, faint, dim, imbecile	strong, vigorous, sane
felicity	joy, happiness, bliss, gladness, blessedness	misfortune, sorrow, grief, misery, sadness
ferocity	cruelty, savagery	kindness, gentleness
fervent	glowing, vehement	cool, unimpassioned
fictitious	false, untrue, not real	true, genuine, actual
figurative	typical, metaphysical	actual, straightforward
finite	bounded, limited	infinite, unlimited
flimsy	slight, thin, trivial	substantial, serious
fluctuate	waver, vacillate, vibrate, oscillate, swing	constant, uniform
fold	crease, crimp, line, wrinkle, pleat	smooth, straighten, unfold
fore-knowledge	farsightedness, foresight	heedlessness,
	forethought, prescience	ignorance, hindsight
forgo	give up, sacrifice, waive	demand, keep, preserve
forswear	abjure, disavow, disclaim, recant, retract	assert, acknowledge, claim, uphold
fortify	secure, strengthen, brace, encourage, entrench	weaken, discourage, unnerve
fragile	weak, brittle, frail, delicate, frangible, friable	strong, solid, tough, flexible, malleable
fraudulent	dishonest, cheating	honest, candour, sincere
frivolous	foolish, vain	grave, serious
frown	grimace, pout, scowl	Smile
funeral	dismal, mournful, gloomy	cheerful, bright
furtive	stealthy, secret, sly, sneaky, surreptitious	open, above board, overt, obvious
futility	useless, vanity, worthlessness	utility, advantage, profitable
gaiety	joyousness, festivity	sadness, mourning
gale	blizzard, breeze, cyclone, hurricane, tornado, typhoon	peace, tranquility
gallantry	courage, bravery, heroism, chivalry	cowardice, poltroonery
ghastly	spectral, pallid, horrible	corporeal, alive, pleasing
gauche	boorish, maladroit, tactless, uncouth, unpolished	urbane, adroit, polite, considerate
genuine	actual, authentic, real, true	artificial, fake, forged, spurious, imaginary
gloomy	dark, dreary, grey, dim	cheerful, bright, gay
gregarious	affable, amiable, cordial, outgoing, sociable	aloof, hostile, antisocial, introverted
glutinous	sticky, viscous	liquid, smooth
gorgeous	splendid, superb, neat	shabby, mean, dirty
grandeur	splendour, greatness	shabbiness, sordidness
gratification	enjoyment, delight	disappointment, dissatisfaction
grim	sullen, surly	mild, gentle
gratuitous	voluntary, spontaneous	mercenary, paid for
grudge	envy, jealousy	goodwill, love

gruesome	ghastly, grim, grisly, hideous, lurid, macabre	charming, delightful, pleasing
gullible	credulous, trusting	critical, doubtful, dubious, skeptical
Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
gush	flow, stream	stop, cease, finish
hackneyed	common, stale	novel, fresh
hamper	shackle, clog, hinder	release, accelerate
hapless	unfortunate, unlucky	lucky, fortunate
harbour	shelter, lodge, dwell	eject, banish, remove
harmony	concord, agreement, accord	discord, disagreement
hazardous	adventurous, bold, dangerous, threatening	timid, safe, protected, safeguarded
heartily	cordially, ardently	insincere, cold
heed	mind, pay attention	disregard, neglect
herculean	laborious, colossal, difficult	slight, easy, simple
homogeneous	uniform, similar, pure	heterogeneous, mixed
hobby	avocation, pastime, sport, recreation	business, labour, livelihood, profession
humane	gentle, kind	cruel, ungentle
hostile	bellicose, unfriendly	cordial, friendly, tolerant
humility	humbleness, modesty	pride, arrogance
humorous	comic, comical, funny, jocular, witty	gloomy, dull, sedate
husky	beefy, stocky, brawny	thin, lean, weak
hypocrisy	deceit, imposture	honesty, sincerely
hypocritical	treacherous, disloyal, false, traitorous	candid, honest, loyal, moral, sincere
identity	sameness, oneness	difference, not similar
imbibe	absorb, engross, assimilate, digest	eject, discharge, vomit
immaculate	spotless, stainless	spotted, stained
immerse	dip, plunge, douse, submerge	draw out
immunity	exemption, release, freedom, privilege	subjection, liability
impatient	restless, hasty	patient, submissive
impeach	accuse, arraign, charge, indict, incriminate	exonerate, pardon, forgive
impediment	hindrance, prevention	facility, liberty
imperative	obligatory, commanding, important, essential	unimportant, submissive, not compulsory
impertinent	irrelevant, impudent	pertinent, relevant
implicate	entangle, involve	Exclude
impel	drive, motivate, move	inhibit, prevent, quell
implicit	implied, inferred, covert	expressed, reserved, exposed
impenetrable	impassable, impermeable, impervious	accessible, open, permeable
imposter	cheat, rogue	honest person
imprudence	thoughtlessness, heedlessness	prudence, carefulness
imitate	ape, copy, mimic, impersonate	create, originate
inaccessible	unapproachable, distant, remote	approachable, accessible
inadvertent	inattentive, careless, oversighted	attentive, heedful, thoughtful
inclement	unmerciful, harsh	clement, merciful
incumbent	binding, compulsory, obligatory	unnecessary, noncompulsory
incite	arouse, exhort, forment	discourage, hinder, subdue
Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)

indemnify	compensate, reward, repay	inflict, loss
industrious	busy, active, laborious	idle, lazy
inevitable	unavoidable, necessary	avoidable, unnecessary
induce	cajole, coax, persuade, urge, wheedle	hinder, repel, subdue, discourage
infirm	debilitated, sickly	strong, healthy, stout
infinite	houndless, illimitable, limitless	circumscribed, finite, limited
infringe	break, violate	submit, obey
insanity	lunacy, madness	sanity, sensibility
insipid	tasteless, dull, flavoured	tasty, well-flavoured
instantaneous	immediate, quick, momentary	future, remote, tardy
intermission	suspension, stoppage	continuance, resume
intervention	interposition, mediation, involvement	neglect, hindrance
intricate	involved, complicated, obscure, knotty	straightforward, simple, clear, easy
intrude	invade, encroach	keep away, respect
insolvent	bankrupt, broke, impecunious	affluent, flush, rich, well-to-do
intuition	insight, instinct	calculation, inference
invigorate	strengthen, stimulate	weaken, unnerve
involuntary	compulsory, automatic	voluntary, spontaneous
intimidate	browbeat, bulldoze, bully, daunt, dismay, terrorise	blandish, encourage, induce
irksome	tiresome, tedious, difficult	pleasant, easy
itinerant	wandering, nomadic	stationary, settled
jaundiced	biased, prejudiced, mistrustful, distrustful	unprejudiced, unbiased, trusting, confident
jeopardise	hazard, endanger	secure, preserve
jeopardy	danger, hazard, menace, peril, risk, threat	defence, protection, safety
jolly	jovial, festive	miserable, dull
jubilant	exulting, rejoicing	despondent, despairing
judicious	discriminating, prudent, well-advised	indiscreet, imprudent
jumble	conglomeration, mess, muddle, farrago, confuse	clear, straightforward, sequential, order, arrange
juvenile	youthful, young	senile, old
jurisdiction	authority, dominion,	forbidding, preventing
kindle	fire, ignite, inflame, light, quench	darken, extinguish, stifle, smother
kidnap	abduct, carry off	restore, bring back
knotty	hard, intricate	smooth, easy, simple
knack	aptitude, faculty, gift	ineptitude, incompetence
laborious	tiresome, wearisome	easy, light, simple
lack	absence, dearth, shortage	abundance, sufficiency
lament	wail, mourn, gloom	rejoice, approve
lavish	excessive, extravagant, prodigal	restrained, economical
laxity	looseness, slackness	tightness, firmness
legend	myth, fable, tradition	true story, fact, reality
lethal	deadly, mortal, fatal	harmless, enlivening, life-giving, invigorating
Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
lofty	high, tall, elevated, towering, outstanding, summit, steep	low, depressed, degraded short

lucrative	profitable, paying	unprofitable, losing
luminous	light, bright	dark, obscure
lunacy	insanity, madness	sanity, mental soundness
lustre	brilliance, brightness	dimness, plainness
luxuriant	abundant, profuse	scanty, barren, scarcity
magnanimous	generous, noble	ungenerous, mean
magnitude	size, bulk, largeness	Smallness
malevolent	malignant, spiteful	benevolent, kindly
malice	spite, hate	charity, love
malign	aspere, defame, libel, slander, vilify, lampoon	praise, eulogise
massive	enormous, hefty, huge, immense, vast	minute, small, thin
manifest	exhibit, show, obvious, conspicuous, evident	conceal, suppress, hidden, implicit, secret
meagre	scanty, poor	plentiful, plump
melancholy	sad, gloomy	gay, joyous
melodious	tuneful, musical	unmelodious, tuneless
mercenary	hired, mean	voluntary, generous
minge	mix, blend	dissolve, disentangle
migrate	emigrate, immigrate, move, travel	remain, stationary
migratory	wandering, unsettled	settled, stationary
miraculous	marvellous, wonderful	normal, natural
miscellaneous	mixed, mingled	individual, separate
misery	sorrow, distress	joy, comfort
miserable	dismal, sorry, unhappy	cheerful, contended, joyous
moderate	restrained, limited	immoderate, excessive
monotonous	uninflected, dull, boring, imperious, tedious, tiresome	melodious, cheerful, modest, stimulating, exciting
monstrous	prodigious, horrible	ordinary, normal
mortal	perishable, deadly	immortal, imperishable
mutable	changeable, variable	settled, unchanging
mutiny	insubordination, revolt	loyalty, subordination
mystify	puzzle, perplex	illuminate, enlighten
myth	fable, legend, saga	fact, history
mythical	legendary, fabulous	actual, historic
native	aboriginal, indigenous, autochthonous, endemic	alien, exotic, foreign, immigrant, imported
nebulous	cloudy, misty, confused	clear, unclouded
nefarious	depraved, corrupt, evil, heinous, villainous	chaste, honest, innocent, moral, pious
nervous	edgy, excitable, fidgety, restless	composed, steady, tranquil, imperturbable
nicety	accuracy, precision	carelessness, indifferent
notorious	disreputable	Reputable
nugatory	trifling, insignificant	important, effective
Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
numb	anaesthetised, insensible, paralysed, deadened	lively, active, vigorous, aware
obedient	dutiful, good, well-behaved	mischievous, stubborn
oblivion	forgetfulness, obscurity	memory, remembrance

oblivious	absent-minded, inattentive, abstracted	aware, observant
obnoxious	exposed, harmful, hateful, odious, offensive	free, cheerful, harmless, humane, lovable, pleasing
obscene	filthy, indecent	pure, clean
obscure	darken, dim, obtruse, arcane, cryptic	clear, explicit, plain, transparent
obtuse	stupid, dull	intelligent, bright
obsessed	addicted, addictive, hooked, compulsive	instinctive, natural
officious	meddlesome, mischievous, obtrusive, prying	harmless, non-interfering, incurious, unofficious, inobtrusive
onerous	burdensome, laborious	light, easy, trifling
opportunistic	ambitious, aspiring, pushy	indolent, lazy, timid, uninvolved
oppress	crush, harass	relieve, help
optimistic	confident, hopeful, sanguine	pessimistic, cynical, defeatist
oration	speech, address	Silence
orifice	opening, aperture, hole	Ending
ostentatious	boastful, pretentious	reticent, restrained
outrageous	atrocious, bold, daring, monstrous, scandalous	timid, appropriate
outstanding	distinguished, dominant, foremost, paramount	mediocre, usual
overbearing	arrogant, domineering	deferential, docile
overture	offer, invitation	withdrawal, finale
pacific	peaceful, gentle	violent, hostile
palatable	tasty, appetising	unpalatable, tasteless
palpable	tangible	Intangible
paltry	little, beggarly	fine, great, sufficient
paramount	supreme, predominant, important, essential	subordinate, inferior, irrelevant, unimportant
paucity	scarcity, fewness, deficiency, inadequate	abundance, multitude, adequate, sufficient
penitence	repentant, remorseful	obstinacy, stubbornness
pensive	thoughtful, sorrowful	active, gay, happy
perennial	everlasting, perpetual	temporary, unending
perseverance	persistence, steadiness	slackness, inconstancy
petition	request, appeal	command, order
piercing	sharp, acute, penetrating	soft, low
piteous	sad, sorrowful, mournful	joyful, cheerful
plague	annoy, harass, pester	please, comfort, solace
plausible	specious, credible, convincing, believable	doubtful, implausible, incredible, suspect
plunge	immerse, dip	draw out, come out
preamble	introduction, preface	conclusion, ending
precarious	risky, uncertain	safe, secure
precedence	priority, preference	Inferiority
Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
precipitate	hasten, expedite, impetuous, impulsive	delay, retard, cautious, impassive, thoughtful
preclude	prevent, stop, hinder, hamper	help, allow, permit
predicate	assert, affirm	deny, doubt
prefatory	introductory, opening	concluding, final

pregnant	full, teeming	empty, meaningless
prejudiced	biased, slanted, subjective	unbiased, disinterested
prejudicial	baneful, biased	unbiased, objective
pretence	affectation, show, pretext	sincerity, reality
prey	victim, capture	captor, hunter
proclamation	announcement, ordinance	Silence
prodigal	extravagant	miser, economic
profane	unconsecrated, impious	sacred, religious
profound	deep, fathomless, excess	shallow, abstruse
profuse	lavish, prodigal	meagre, sharing
progeny	decendant, offspring	Ancestors
prolific	productive, fruitful	unproductive, barren
prohibit	ban, debar, enjoin, forbid	endorse, permit, allow
prone	inclined, prostrate	averse, upright
propel	press, push, shove, thrust, urge	discourage, pull, stop
proscribe	outlaw, denounce	pardon, forgive
prosecute	indict, pursue	abandon, defend
prototype	archetype, exemplar, ideal, original	copy, counterpart, duplicate
provident	foreseeing, thrifty	improvident, extravagant
provisional	conditional, contingent, tentative, dependent	conclusive, definite, permanent
prudent	judicious, cautious, economical, frugal	imprudent, injudicious, incautious
pungent	sharp, stinking	mild, harmless
quack	charlatan, imposter	professional, qualified
quash	annul, cancel	ratify, confirm, restore
quell	calm, placate, subdue	Noisy
quench	extinguish, put out	light, ignite, arouse
radiance	brilliancy, lustre	dullness, dimness
radical	fundamental, organic	superficial, incomplete
ragged	torn, jagged	untorn, even
raid	foray, incursion, invasion, sortie	depress, descend, lower
random	casual, desultory, haphazard	formal, invariable, orderly, systematic
rancid	tainted, sour	untainted, sweet
rational	intelligent, reasonable	irrational, foolish
rebuff	reprimand, rebuke	encourage, approve
recede	retire, withdraw	advance, retreat
reciprocal	mutual, correlative	selfish, individual
reckless	rash, regardless	cautious, prudent
Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
rectify	repair, renew, remedy, renovate	destroy, save, keep, conserve, repair
redeem	buy back, recover	retain, detain
redundant	exuberant, excessive	scanty, deficient
relinquish	abandon, abdicate, cede, renounce, resign, yield	retain, cherish, possess, maintain
remission	abatement, relaxation	increase, augmentation
repudiate	renounce, reject	allow, admit
repugnant	distasteful, offensive	agreeable, pleasant
repulsive	abhorrent, abominable, disgusting,	admirable, alluring, amiable, charming

resolute	loathsome	irresolute, undecided
respite	determined, firm	continuance, perpetuity
restoration	pause, cessation	destruction, withholding
restraint	recovery, reinstatement	freedom, frankness
retrospect	check, hindrance	Prospect
reveal	review	conceal, hide
revive	publish, disclose	depress, deject
revolt	renew, reanimate	loyal, obey, submit
ridiculous	rebel, mutiny	grave, serious
righteousness	laughable, absurd	ungodliness, dishonesty
robust	uprightness, goodness	thin, lean, weak, fragile
ruinous	strong, hale, stout, lusty, portly	whole, sound
rupture	dilapidated, harmful	union, attachment
rustic	breach, break	urbane, polished
sacrilegious	rural, simple, rude, clownish	pious, reverent
sacred	profane, impious	temporal, worldly
sad	blessed, consecrated	joyous, blithe, cheerful, jubilant, lively
saddle	dejected, depressed, despondent, disconsolate	unload, disburden
sane	load, burden	unsound, confused, unreasonable, insane
saucy	sound, healthy, sensible, reasonable	polite, reserved
savoury	impertinent, rude	unsavoury, tasteless
sarcastic	tasty, palatable, spicy	complimentary, flattering, favourable
scandal	biting, caustic, cutting, sardonic	credit, praise
scandalous	shame, infamy, slander	appropriate, commendable, humane, polite
scanty	atrocious, monstrous	abundant, plentiful, adequate
scatter	insufficient, meagre, inadequate, scarce	retain, hold, gather, unite
sceptic	sprinkle, disperse, diffuse, disseminate	believer, bigot, pietist, religious, zealot
seclusion	agnostic, atheist, doubter, unbeliever	publicity, union
secular	separation, withdrawal	religious, eternal, pious
sedate	temporal, civil, lay, profane, worldly	perturbed, agitated, fighty, light-hearted
seductive	calm, composed, sober, serious, solemn, staid	repelling, chill, dissuade
semblance	alluring, enticing, attractive, luring	Unlikeness
sensual	resemblance, likeness	ascetic, spiritual
Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
servile	slavish, menial	masterly, lordly
shackle	fetter, hamper	loose, release
shuffle	mix, confuse	clear, be frank
slender	slim, fragile, weak, thin	fat, bulky, stout, strong
sloth	torpor, inactivity, laziness	activity, vigour
smite	strike, beat, hit	spare, repair
snug	close, comfortable	Uncomfortable
smudge	soil, besmirch, dirty	bleach, clean, purify
sober	moderate, calm	immoderate, excited
solace	console, comfort, peace	vex, pain, irritation

solemn	formal, ceremonial	informal, profane
solicitude	care, concern, worry, anxiety	careless, unconcerned
solitary	lone, single, secluded	companionable, sociable
sophistry	casuistry, hair-splitting	Uncontroversial
sordid	dirty, foul, filthy	clean, polished
sovereign	royal, regal, authority	subject, ineffectual
speculation	thought, theory	action, fact
speculator	barracker, observer	performer, participant
splendid	gorgeous, sumptuous	shabby, cheap
spontaneous	voluntary, without preparation	involuntary, with prior preparation
spurious	illegitimate, forged, counterfeit, shoddy	genuine, authentic, accurate, sincere
squander	dissipate, waste	save, economise
stagnant	still, motionless, stationary	running, moving, in action
stake	risk, hazard	shirk, avoid
staunch	firm, resolute	infirm, unsteady
steadfast	fixed, established	unfixed, infirm
steep	abrupt, precipitous	flat, gentle, level, low
sterile	arid, barren, childless, unfruitful	bearing, fruitful, viable, yielding, productive
stimulate	arouse, stir	calm, tranquil
stout	strong, robust, portly	thin, lean, weak
stray	wander, err, deviate	stay, continue
stringent	astringent, contracting, tight	relaxing, gentle
strip	denude, uncover, bare	cover, clothe
stubborn	obstinate, unyielding, adamant, inflexible	adaptable, docile, yielding, tractable
sublime	high, exalted	low, depressed
subdue	check, constrain, curb, repress, restrain, suppress	incite, stimulate
subservient	ancillary, inferior, unscrupulous	superior, leading, scrupulous
subsistence	living, existence	Starvation
subtle	nice, delicate, rare, thin, crafty	rough, coarse, unrefined, simple
subvert	overthrow, destroy	reconstruct, restore
sumptuous	costly, expensive	cheap, simple

Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
superfluous	redundant, useless, harmful, unprofitable	useful, beneficial, profitable, serviceable
superlative	highest, greatest	lowest, smallest
surmise	suspect, suppose	know, be sure, exact
susceptible	sensitive, impressionable	insusceptible, hard
suspicious	doubtful, questionable	certain, trustful, clear
swell	dilate, expand, bulge	diminish, lessen, deflate
symbolical	typical, representative	Actual
synonymous	equivalent, similar	dissimilar, contrary
tacit	implied, implicit	explicit, expressed
taciturn	close, reticent, uncommunicative, secretive	communicative, open, unreserved, talkative
tangible	tactile, substantial	impalpable, unreal
tantamount	equivalent, equal	unequal, non-equivalent
taunt	jeer, flout, scoff, gibe	soothe, commend, praise
tedious	wearisome, irksome	delightful, agreeable

tenacity	adhesiveness, obstinacy	looseness, inertia
terrestrial	earthy, worldly	heavenly, celestial
testimony	witness, deposition	concealment, denial
theatrical	dramatic, showy, histrionic	natural, real, prosaic
terse	compendious, laconic, concise, brief	lengthy, talkative, tedious
thrifty	provident, economical	prodigal, uneconomic
thriftless	wasteful, improvident, spendthrift	cautious, frugal, miserly, thrifty
thwart	oppose, frustrate, balk, foil, inhibit	help, advance, permit, allow
tipsy	intoxicated, drunk, nervous, shaken, agitated	sober, calm, composed, cool
torment	pain, torture	comfort, easy, tranquil
tortuous	twisted, winding, crooked	straight, honest, simple
tranquil	calm, quiet, composed, peaceful	disturbed, agitated
treachery	disloyalty, perfidy	loyalty, faith
trench	infringe, trespass	respect, observe
trifle	toy, play, wanton	Serious
trivial	paltry, petty	significant, important
triumph	victory, achievement	lament, fail
turbulent	blustering, riotous, stormy, violent	tranquil, peaceful
turmoil	bustle, confusion, hurry	quiet, peacefulness
turpitude	baseness, depravity, wickedness, vileness	worthiness, goodness
tyrant	despot, autocrat	constitutional, sovereign
tyro	beginner, novice, neophyte	expert, old hand, veteran
unethical	amoral, immoral, unprincipled	moral, principled
unanimous	accordant, harmonious	discordant, disagreeing
unique	solve, single, unmatched	common, frequent
uphold	back, champion, defend	betray, destroy, drop
urbane	cultivated, genteel, sophisticated	brusque, gauche, vulgar
Word	Synonyms (similar meaning)	Antonyms (opposite meaning)
urbanity	civility, politeness	rudeness, harshness
utopian	ideal, imaginary	practical, real
vacillation	hesitation, wavering	decision, firmness
vagrant	wandering, roaming	settled, homely
vague	uncertain, indefinite	certain, definite, sure
vain	empty, worthless	useful, effective
valiant	brave, gallant	cowardly, unheroic
validity	efficiency, authority	inefficiency, weakness
vanish	disappear, pass away	appear, live, survive
vehement	violent, boisterous	weak, cold, lean
veil	screen, hide, conceal	disclose, uncover
velocity	swiftness, rapidity	slowness, tardiness
venerable	reverend, grave	trifling, light
verbose	wordy, diffuse, long-winded, repetitious	terse, silent, speechless
veracity	truth, reality, correctness	fiction, unreality
vexatious	annoying, harassing, irritating, knotty	satisfying, pleasing, soothing, easy, simple
vicious	faulty, defective, corrupt, depraved	perfect, incorrupt, moral
viable	fertile, fruitful	aborted, sterile, untenable

vibrate	fluctuate, oscillate	stationary, motionless
vigour	power, strength	weakness, sickness
vindictive	revengeful, spiteful, malevolent, malicious	benevolent, kindly, forgiving, friendly, generous, humane
vivid	lively, clear	dull, unimpressive
vogue	fashion, usage, trend	unpopular, outdated
voluntary	spontaneous, free	Involuntary
voracious	greedy, ravenous	satiable, satisfied
vulnerable	weak, exposed, untenable, defenceless	fortified, strong, invulnerable, guarded, invincible
wander	meander, ramble, range, roam, rove, stray	remain, rest, settle, steady
wariness	caution, circumspection, vigilance, watchfulness	incautious, careless
warrant	guarantee, certify, authorise	forbid, disallow
wearisome	fatiguing, irksome, tiring, tedious	refreshing, restful
whimsical	freakish, fanciful, eccentric, capricious	serious, staid
wistful	pensive, thoughtful, dreamy, moody, nostalgic	cheerful, happy, heedless, airy, flippant
wretched	unfortunate, sad, miserable, dismal, sorry	fortunate, happy, joyous, contented
wrinkle	fold, crease, crimp, pleat	smooth surface, flat, straighten
yearn	hanker, long, pine, crave, covet, long for	be satisfied, be contented
yield	forgo, give in, surrender, relinquish, concede	resist, withhold, refuse
yoke	link, bondage, slavery	freedom, liberty
zeal	passion, eagerness	apathy, weakness
zenith	top, apex, climax, pinnacle, summit	base, bottom, foot, low
zest	brio, dash, drive, energy, gusto, pleasure, spirit	dullness, blandness, exhaustion, dislike, weariness, distaste

B) Using Connotative and Denotative Word Meaning

Connotation refers to a meaning suggested or implied by the use of a particular word, beyond its literal (denotative) meaning. Connotation impacts how readers perceive the overall meaning of what a writer or speaker is trying to communicate. Depending on how a word has been used over time, or the context in which it is being used, the term may have a positive, negative or neutral connotation.

Connotative vs. Denotative Meanings

To fully understand a word and use it correctly, you need to know both its denotation (the standard definition) and its connotation (the feelings associated with it).

- The **denotative** meaning of a word is its official dictionary definition.
- A word's **connotative** meaning includes shades of meaning, such as emotions, associated with the term.

The Importance of Connotation

When choosing words to use in language, it's important to consider both types of meaning. This is an important key to choosing the right words. If you aren't fully aware of a word's connotation, you may choose an inappropriate synonym in your writing, which can lead to confusion or even to your reader taking offense.

Example: Birthday Activity Request

If you say that you want to do something **different** for your birthday this year, that doesn't convey the same meaning as if you said you wanted to do something **unique**. The denotative meanings of "different" and "unique" are similar (not the same or unlike). However, the connotative meanings of these two words are not the same.

- **Different** would mean something other than what you did last year or in previous years.
- **Unique** would imply something highly unusual, such as an activity not commonly associated with birthdays or something that you (or most people) have never done before

Someone trying to come up with a way to celebrate your birthday will probably find it much more challenging to identify a "unique" activity rather than one that is just "different."

Example: Describing a Group

As another example, consider the words **group**, **clique**, **club**, and **gang**. All four have basically the same denotative meaning: a set of more than one person. Each of these words has a different connotative meaning, however.

- **Group** has a neutral connotation. The word simply describes a number of people. It does not inspire either positive or negative feelings.
- **Clique** also means a group of people, but it carries a negative connotation. This is because "clique" is typically used in circumstances where the group is known for excluding others. This word should be used carefully: If you want to be thought of as a welcoming group, the negative connotation of this word will turn people off!
- **Gang** is defined as an organized group, but it has very negative connotations. The use of this term suggests criminal activity and/or violent behavior.

- **Club** also refers to a group of people, but this word has a more positive connotation because a club is a collection of people that voluntarily come together for a shared passion or purpose.

Example: Describing Demeanor

If you know someone whose personality style is the opposite of high-strung, it's important to choose an appropriate word to describe the person's demeanor. Should you use relaxed, lackadaisical or easygoing?

- **Relaxed** is a fairly neutral or positive way to describe someone's temperament, but it doesn't imply that the person is this way all the time. Someone could be relaxed now, but become very agitated or excited at another time.
- **Easygoing** is also likely to be perceived as a positive or natural description. It is more likely to be viewed as a general statement about a person's general nature rather than a snapshot of a moment in time.
- **Lackadaisical** is never a compliment. Someone who is lackadaisical is relaxed and easygoing, but that person is also probably careless and disengaged. This term has a negative connotation.

Connotative Words: Examples

To see more examples of how words with similar denotations can have positive, neutral or negative connotations, refer to the chart below.

Positive Connotation	Neutral Connotation	Negative Connotation
Interested	Curious	nosy
Employ	use	exploit
Thrifty	saving	stingy
Steadfast	tenacious	stubborn
Sated	filled	crammed
Courageous	confident	conceited
Unique	Different	peculiar
Meticulous	Selective	picky
Vintage	Old	decrepit
Elated	Happy	manic

Connotative Meaning: Practical Exercises

Now that you're more familiar with connotative words, see how well you do with these fun exercises. The answers are below, so don't look ahead until you have tried to answer on your own.

Exercise 1: Finding Words with Negative Connotations

Read the sentences below. Identify the word(s) that have a negative connotation.

1. Bedford is a gritty neighborhood, but the rent is affordable.
2. On my flight to Los Angeles, I sat next to this geezer. He was very old.

3. Every morning my neighbor takes his mutt to the park. It always barks loudly when leaving the building.
4. You need to be pushy when you are looking for a job.
5. Bob is bullheaded sometimes, but he always gets the job done.

Exercise 2: Choose a Word with a Positive Connotation

Choose the word with the most positive connotation to complete the sentences below.

1. I love spending time with my aunt. She has a very (childlike, youthful, childish) outlook on life.
2. I enjoy finding ways to make the most of my budget by being (frugal, miserly, cheap).
3. I am (confident, arrogant, egotistical) that I will be selected for a role in the school play.
4. I realize that you're feeling (nosy, prying, inquisitive), but I'd rather not discuss the matter.
5. My cousin is very (blathering, jabbering, talkative).

Exercise 3: What's the Connotation?

For each of the sentences below, determine if the bold word has a positive or negative connotation.

1. How long have you been dieting? Maybe too long. You look so **skinny**.
2. I can tell you put a lot of work into your book report. It is **extraordinary**.
3. I hope to look like my sister when I grow up. She is absolutely **gorgeous**.
4. I know that Eddie and I are the same age, but he is just so **juvenile**.
5. It's certainly **unusual** to use Comic Sans font on a resume.

Answers for Exercise 1: Finding Words with Negative Connotations

The terms with a negative connotation are marked in bold.

1. Bedford is a **gritty** neighborhood, but the rent is affordable.
2. On my flight to Los Angeles, I sat next to this **geezer**. He was very old.
3. Every morning my neighbor takes his **mutt** to the park. It always barks loudly when leaving the building.
4. You need to be **pushy** when you are looking for a job.
5. Bob is **bullheaded** sometimes, but he always gets the job done.

Answers for Exercise 2: Choose a Word with a Positive Connotation

Options with the most positive connotation are marked in bold.

1. I love spending time with my aunt. She has a very (childlike, **youthful**, childish) outlook on life.
2. I enjoy finding ways to make the most of my budget by being (**frugal**, miserly, cheap).
3. I am (**confident**, arrogant, egotistical) that I will be selected for a role in the school play.
4. I realize that you're feeling (nosy, prying, **inquisitive**), but I'd rather not discuss the matter.
5. My cousin is very (blathering, **talkative**, jabbering).

Exercise 3: What's the Connotation?

Answers appear in parentheses after each sentence.

1. How long have you been dieting? Maybe too long. You look so **skinny**. (negative - implies the person has lost too much weight)
2. I can tell you put a lot of work into your book report. It is **extraordinary**. (positive - implies that the results are very good)
3. I hope to look like my sister when I grow up. She is absolutely **gorgeous**. (positive - implies great beauty)
4. I know that Eddie and I are the same age, but he is just so **juvenile**. (negative - implies immature and childish)
5. It's certainly **unusual** to use Comic Sans font on a resume. (negative - implies that this is a bad idea)

Use Context to Get a Sense of the Word

As you can see, it's important to understand the connotation as well as the denotation of a word before you use it. Otherwise, you run the risk of picking a word that doesn't effectively communicate your intended meaning. It takes practice to understand both the connotation and denotation of a new word, but it's well worth the effort. The best way to learn a word's connotation is to review it in actual sentences to get a sense of how it is used. There are many [examples of connotation in literature](#) to review. It's also helpful to compare how synonyms are used so you can see which are positive, negative or neutral. These strategies can help prepare you to select the best denotative and connotative words for your purposes.

C) Using Collocation

What is collocation?

A collocation is a pair or group of words that are often used together. These combinations sound natural to native speakers, but students of English have to make a special effort to learn them because they are often difficult to guess. Some combinations just sound 'wrong' to native speakers of English. For example, the adjective *fast* collocates with *cars*, but not with *a glance*.

Learning collocations is an important part of learning the vocabulary of a language. Some collocations are fixed, or very strong, for example **take a photo**, where no word other than *take* collocates with *photo* to give the same meaning. Some collocations are more open, where several different words may be used to give a similar meaning, for example **keep to / stick to the rules**. Here are some more examples of collocations.

- You must **make an effort** and study for your exams (NOT do an effort)
- Did you **watch TV** last night? (NOT look at TV)
- This car has a very **powerful engine**. It can do 200 km an hour. (NOT strong engine)
- There are some **ancient monuments** nearby. (NOT antique monuments)

Sometimes, a pair of words may not be absolutely wrong, and people will understand what is meant, but it may not be the natural, normal collocation. If someone says *I did a few mistakes*, they will be understood, but a fluent speaker of English would probably say **I made a few mistakes**.

Compounds are units of meaning formed with two or more words. Sometimes the words are written separately, sometimes they have a hyphen and sometimes they are written as one word. Usually the meaning of the compound can be guessed by knowing the meaning of the individual words. Some examples of compounds are **car park**, **post office**, **narrow-minded**, **shoelaces**, **tea pot**.

It is not always easy to separate collocations and compounds and, where they are useful for learners or an important part of the vocabulary of a topic, we include some compounds in this book too.

Idioms are groups of words in a fixed order that have a meaning that cannot be guessed by knowing the meaning of the individual words. For example, **pass the buck** is an idiom meaning 'to pass responsibility for a problem to another person to avoid dealing with it oneself'. We deal with idioms in detail in the book *English Idioms in Use* in this series.

Why learn collocations?

Learning collocations is a good idea because they can:

- give you the most natural way to say something: *smoking is **strictly forbidden*** is more natural than *smoking is strongly forbidden*.
- give you alternative ways of saying something, which may be more colourful/expressive or more precise: instead of repeating *It was **very cold** and **very dark***, we can say *It was **bitterly cold** and **pitch dark***.
- improve your style in writing: instead of saying *poverty **causes crime***, you can say *poverty **breeds crime***; instead of saying *a **big meal*** you can say *a **substantial meal***. You may not need or want to use these in informal conversations, but in writing they can give your text more variety and make it read better: this book includes notes about formality wherever the collocations are especially formal or informal.

Noticing Collocations

Some Common Types of Collocations Found in Academic Texts*	
Collocations	Examples
Adjective + noun	key issues, persistent problems, wide range, further research, current theory, larger context, detailed references, essential information, prior knowledge, practical applications, straightforward approach
Verb + adverb (or adverb + verb)	develop further, demonstrate conclusively, present effectively, explore thoroughly, highly appreciate, successfully complete
Verb + noun	acquire vocabulary, gain awareness, reach a goal, address the issue, raise the question, develop a theory, provide a framework, set the scene, clarify the point
Phrasal verbs	depend on, relate to, focus on, bring together, deal with, consist of, respond to, lead to, serve as, point out
Prepositional phrases	in that case, in any case, on the whole, with regard to, in other words

Collocations with the word “population” in English

For example: **population** *noun*

a. Adjective:

✓ **large | small, sparse | overall, total**

The country has a total population of 65 million.

✓ | **global, local, national, world | indigenous, native | adult, ageing, elderly, young, youthful | female, male | black, white | active, working**

Most of the economically active population is employed in the primary industries.

✓ | **student | civil, civilian | prison, school | rural, urban | general**

The general population was in favor of the National Health Service.

b. Population + Verb

✓ **be sth, stand at sth**

The population now stands at about 4 million.

✓ | **reach sth | exceed sth | double, grow, increase, rise | decline, decrease, fall | consist of sth | live**

The majority of the population lives in these two towns.

c. Population + Noun

✓ **levels, size | density | data, estimate, figures, projections, trends**

No reliable population estimates exist.

✓ | **growth, increase | decline, loss | ageing | explosion | census | centre**

Major population centers along the coast

d. Phrase

✓ **a decline/an increase in population, the growth of population**

The rapid growth of population led to an acute shortage of housing.

✓ | **per head of population**

The income per head of population was under £1,000 per annum.

Verb + Noun Collocations Lists:

Here is a list of some of the most common **verb and noun collocations** with its meanings.

- | | | |
|---|--|--|
| 1. Have a drink – get something to drink | 4. Break a record – achieve a new record | 9. Pay your respects – show someone you respect them |
| 2. Have breakfast / lunch / dinner – eat something for a meal | 5. Break a leg – to do well | 10. Make a difference – change something |
| 3. Have a good time – enjoy yourself | 6. Break the law – not follow the rules | 11. Make money – to earn |
| | 7. Pay attention – to be focused | 12. Make progress – to improve |
| | 8. Pay a visit – go to visit someone | 13. Save money – set money aside |

14. Save time – do something efficiently	22. Catch a bus – get on a bus in time	29. Go bankrupt – lose all your money
15. Save energy – conserve energy	23. Catch a cold – get sick	30. Go missing – disappear
16. Do business – conduct business	24. Catch a thief – capture a thief	31. Get a job – find employment
17. Do someone a favor – do something for someone	25. Come prepared – be prepared before a task	32. Get drunk – drink a lot
18. Do your best – give all your effort to a task	26. Come to a decision – make a decision	33. Get started – start something
19. Take a break – pause work	27. Come first – finish a contest in first place	34. Keep a promise – fulfill a promise you made
20. Take a look – see something up close	28. Go bad – when food becomes rotten	35. Keep calm – be calm in a tough situation
21. Take notes – write down important information		36. Keep quiet – stay quiet

Examples in Sentence Constructions:

1. Have a drink

- Can I have a drink, please? Yes, of course. What do you want to have? A glass of white wine, please.

2. Have breakfast

- Do you want to eat something before the class? No, thanks, I have had breakfast at home.

3. Have a good time

- Are you travelling somewhere? Yes, I'm going camping to the seaside. Have a good time.

4. Break a record

- I broke my own record at running. I ran 5 kilometers in 30 minutes last time. It's 2 minutes faster than my previous run.

5. Break a leg

- I'm going to my hardest exam today. Wish me good luck. Break a leg. You can do it.

6. Break the law

- She broke the law, so now she is in prison for years.

7. Pay attention

- Please, pay attention, I'm talking to you!

8. Pay a visit

- I paid a visit to my grandmother. She is not very well.

9. Pay your respects

- You should pay your respects to the director. He is older and wiser than you.

10. Make money

- I have to find a second job. I want to make more money.

11. Make progress

- I want to make progress in my career. I'm going to training.

12. Save money

- I want to save a big amount of money for my retirement because I'm not expecting any pension from the government.

13. Save time

- A saved time, because I made half of the cooking yesterday evening. Now I just have to put it in the oven.

14. Save energy

- I saved a lot of energy because I bought some energy saver lights for my house.

15. Do business

- He did his best business this week. He just signed the contract for a 1.000.000 dollar reconstruction.

16. Do someone a favor

- Could you please do me a big favor? I won't have time to walk with my dog today. Would you mind doing it?

17. Take a break

- Let's take a break, and have lunch in the canteen.

18. Take a look

- Could you take a look at my calculation? I'm not sure it's correct.

19. Take notes

- Please take notes during the presentation.

20. Catch a bus

- I don't have time; I have to catch the next bus.

21. Catch a cold

- Sorry, I can't go with you; I caught a cold. I'm not feeling very well.

22. Come prepared

- Did you come prepared to this challenge?

23. Come to a decision

- Did you come to a decision? Will you marry him?

24. Come first

- Don't worry, you came prepared, you come first.

25. Go bankrupt

- She gambled, and she went bankrupt.

26. Go missing

- Her wife went missing. Even cops can't find her.

27. Get a job

- Finally, she got a job. She has been looking for it for ages.

28. Get drunk

- Last night, they got drunk, so they went home by taxi.

29. Get started

- Let's get started with the diet. It will be easier together.

30. Keep a promise

- I kept my promise; I took him to the beach for his birthday.

31. Keep calm

- Keep calm; she will be ok soon.

32. Keep quiet

- If you keep quiet, you will hear the birdsong.